The Gospel of

JOHN

CHAPTERS 8 - 21

Abide in me, and I in you. As the branch cannot bear fruit by itself, unless it abides in the vine, neither can you, unless you abide in me.

ACTS2 DEVOTIONS

JAN - APR 2026

Memory Verses

John 1:14	And the Word became flesh and dwelt among us, and we have seen his glory, glory as of the only Son from the Father, full of grace and truth.
John 1:29	The next day he saw Jesus coming toward him, and said, "Behold, the Lamb of God, who takes away the sin of the world!"
John 1:45-46	Philip found Nathanael and said to him, "We have found him of whom Moses in the Law and also the prophets wrote, Jesus of Nazareth, the son of Joseph." Nathanael said to him, "Can anything good come out of Nazareth?" Philip said to him, "Come and see."
John 3:3	Jesus answered him, "Truly, truly, I say to you, unless one is born again he cannot see the kingdom of God."
John 3:16-17	"For God so loved the world, that he gave his only Son, that whoever believes in him should not perish but have eternal life. For God did not send his Son into the world to condemn the world, but in order that the world might be saved through him."
John 4:34	Jesus said to them, "My food is to do the will of him who sent me and to accomplish his work."
John 5:24	"Truly, truly, I say to you, whoever hears my word and believes him who sent me has eternal life. He does not come into judgment, but has passed from death to life."
John 6:68-69	Simon Peter answered him, "Lord, to whom shall we go? You have the words of eternal life, and we have believed, and have come to know, that you are the Holy One of God."
John 7:38	"Whoever believes in me, as the Scripture has said, 'Out of his heart will flow rivers of living water.'"

Memory Verses

1 Thessalonians 5:16-18	Rejoice always, pray without ceasing, give thanks in all circumstances; for this is the will of God in Christ Jesus for you.
Habakkuk 3:17-18	Though the fig tree should not blossom, nor fruit be on the vines, the produce of the olive fail and the fields yield no food, the flock be cut off from the fold and there be no herd in the stalls, yet I will rejoice in the LORD; I will take joy in the God of my salvation.
Colossians 1:11-12	being strengthened with all power, according to his glorious might, for all endurance and patience with joy, giving thanks to the Father, who has qualified you to share in the inheritance of the saints in light.
1 Timothy 1:15	The saying is trustworthy and deserving of full acceptance, that Christ Jesus came into the world to save sinners, of whom I am the foremost.
Isaiah 9:6	For to us a child is born, to us a son is given; and the government shall be upon his shoulder, and his name shall be called Wonderful Counselor, Mighty God, Everlasting Father, Prince of Peace.
Luke 2:10-11	And the angel said to them, "Fear not, for behold, I bring you good news of great joy that will be for all the people. For unto you is born this day in the city of David a Savior, who is Christ the Lord."
Ephesians 2:8-10	For by grace you have been saved through faith. And this is not your own doing; it is the gift of God, not a result of works, so that no one may boast. For we are his workmanship, created in Christ Jesus for good works, which God prepared beforehand, that we should walk in them.
Ephesians 3:20-21	Now to him who is able to do far more abundantly than all that we ask or think, according to the power at work within us, to him be glory in the church and in Christ Jesus throughout all generations, forever and ever. Amen.
Ephesians 5:1-2	Therefore be imitators of God, as beloved children. And walk in love, as Christ loved us and gave himself up for us, a fragrant offering and sacrifice to God.

Memory Verses

John 8:12	Again Jesus spoke to them, saying, "I am the light of the world. Whoever follows me will not walk in darkness, but will have the light of life."
John 10:10-11	"The thief comes only to steal and kill and destroy. I came that they may have life and have it abundantly. I am the good shepherd. The good shepherd lays down his life for the sheep."
John 10:27-28	"My sheep hear my voice, and I know them, and they follow me. I give them eternal life, and they will never perish, and no one will snatch them out of my hand."
John 11:25	Jesus said to her, "I am the resurrection and the life. Whoever believes in me, though he die, yet shall he live."
John 12:24-25	"Truly, truly, I say to you, unless a grain of wheat falls into the earth and dies, it remains alone; but if it dies, it bears much fruit. Whoever loves his life loses it, and whoever hates his life in this world will keep it for eternal life."
John 13:34-35	"A new commandment I give to you, that you love one another: just as I have loved you, you also are to love one another. By this all people will know that you are my disciples, if you have love for one another."
John 15:5	"I am the vine; you are the branches. Whoever abides in me and I in him, he it is that bears much fruit, for apart from me you can do nothing."
John 15:12-13	"This is my commandment, that you love one another as I have loved you. Greater love has no one than this, that someone lay down his life for his friends."
John 16:33	"I have said these things to you, that in me you may have peace. In the world you will have tribulation. But take heart; I have overcome the world."
John 17:22-23	"The glory that you have given me I have given to them, that they may be one even as we are one, I in them and you in me, that they may become perfectly one, so that the world may know that you sent me and loved them even as you loved me."
John 12:32	"And I, when I am lifted up from the earth, will draw all people to myself."
John 20:31	But these are written so that you may believe that Jesus is the Christ, the Son of God, and that by believing you may have life in his name.

Hymn of the Month

JANUARY

More Love to Thee, O Christ

More love to Thee, O Christ, more love to Thee!
Hear Thou the prayer I make on bended knee;
This is my earnest plea:
More love, O Christ, to Thee,
More love to Thee, more love to Thee!

Once earthly joy I craved, sought peace and rest;
Now Thee alone I seek, give what is best;
This all my prayer shall be:
More love, O Christ, to Thee,
More love to Thee, more love to Thee!

Then shall my latest breath whisper Thy praise;
This be the parting cry my heart shall raise;
This still its prayer shall be:
More love, O Christ, to Thee,
More love to Thee, more love to Thee!

Author: Elizabeth Prentiss
Composer: William Howard Doane

FEBRUARY

Abide With Me

Abide with me, fast falls the eventide;
The darkness deepens, Lord, with me abide.
When other helpers fail and comforts flee,
Help of the helpless, O, abide with me!

Swift to its close ebbs out life's little day;
Earth's joys grow dim, its glories pass away;
Change and decay in all around I see;
O Thou who changest not, abide with me!

I need Thy presence ev'ry passing hour;
What but Thy grace can foil the tempter's pow'r?
Who like Thyself my guide and stay can be?
Through cloud and sunshine, O abide with me!

I fear no foe with Thee at hand to bless,
Though ills have weight and tears their bitterness
Where is death's sting? Where, grave, Thy victory?
I triumph still, if Thou abide with me.

Hold Thou Thy cross before my closing eyes;
Shine through the gloom, and point me to the skies;
Heaven's morning breaks and earth's vain shadows flee;
In life, in death, O Lord, abide with me!

Author: Henry F. Lyte
Composer: William Henry Monk

MARCH

Because He Lives

God sent His son
They called Him Jesus
He came to love
Heal, and forgive
He lived and died
To buy my pardon,
An empty grave is there to prove
My Savior lives.

Because He lives
I can face tomorrow.
Because He lives
All fear is gone.
Because I know He holds the future,
And life is worth the living
Just because He lives.

How sweet to hold
A newborn baby,
And feel the pride
And joy he brings;
But greater still
The calm assurance:
This child can face
Uncertain days because He lives!

And then one day I'll cross the river,
I'll fight life's final war with pain.
And then as death gives way to victory,
I'll see the lights of glory and
I'll know He lives.

Artist: Bill Gaither

APRIL

In Christ Alone

In Christ alone my hope is found
He is my light, my strength, my song
This cornerstone, this solid ground
Firm through the fiercest drought and storm
What heights of love, what depths of peace
When fears are stilled, when strivings cease
My Comforter, my all in all
Here in the love of Christ I stand

There in the ground His body lay
Light of the world by darkness slain
Then bursting forth in glorious day
Up from the grave He rose again
And as He stands in victory
Sin's curse has lost its grip on me
For I am His and He is mine
Bought with the precious blood of Christ

No guilt in life, no fear in death
This is the power of Christ in me
From life's first cry to final breath
Jesus commands my destiny
No power of hell, no scheme of man
Can ever pluck me from His hand
'Til He returns or calls me home
Here in the power of Christ I'll stand

I find my strength, I find my hope
I find my help in Christ alone
When fear assails, when darkness falls
I find my peace in Christ alone
I give my life, I give my all
I sing this song to Christ alone
The King of kings, the Lord of all
All heaven sings to Christ alone
To Christ alone
To Christ alone

'Til He returns or calls me home
Here in the power of Christ I'll stand
Here in the power of Christ we stand

Artist: Kristian Stanfill

Journal

Please use one of the prompts below to get your journaling started.

- Recall a significant reaction, conversation or event.
- Explore your fears and what's behind them.
- Write about a relational conflict you are experiencing.
- List out all that you are grateful for.

Commentary on John 8

vv. 8-11 "Numerous problems accompany their charge this day in the temple. (1) The law also expected that if a person witnessed another about to commit a sin, compassion required them to speak up. These witnesses stand silently, neglecting their moral obligation to give guidance to the woman. They want to catch her and use her.

"(2) We must ask if the woman is married or betrothed to another man. A woman who is sexually unfaithful to her fiancé was to be stoned to death along with her lover (John 8:5; cf. Deut. 22:23 – 24). [...] In the present passage, the woman therefore must be engaged. But if so, where is her lover? If they were caught in the act, he was caught too. The accusers have permitted him to get away clean.

"(3) These witnesses bring the woman to Jesus before a crowd and heap public shame on her. They could have kept her to one side and brought her case to Jesus privately. But their approach to the problem indicates that they wish to trap Jesus, and her personal life is incidental (8:6). They have no interest in a trial. They are thinking about a public lynching, and they want Jesus to make a judgment.

"It is impossible to know what Jesus wrote in the dust (8:6). For some interpreters, Jesus was simply drawing to give himself added time. More likely, however, a detail like this had some importance. Most believe that he began to write in Hebrew some verse from the law that would shape his response to the dilemma. [...]

"If his writing seemed to stall things, 8:7 indicates that these men persist to force the question of judgment on him before the crowd. Jesus responds with his often-quoted statement, 'If any one of you is without sin, let him be the first to throw a stone at her.' This does not mean that this woman's accusers must be sinless or morally perfect in order to bring charges against the woman. In such a case, accusations would be impossible at any time. [...]

"But then the accusers must engage in self-examination. The world of antiquity was little different from our own when it came to sexual sins. Women who transgressed social mores could find themselves in legal jeopardy much more quickly than their partners. Jesus may thus be cutting through the double standard in order to force the men to reflect on their own hypocrisy."

vv. 31-59 "The opponents of Jesus now turn back accusations on him (8:48). If it is true that his opponents are children of the devil, then he must be a Samaritan and demon-possessed. This is a radical dishonoring. "Samaritan" (see comments on John 4) refers to those people living north of Jerusalem near Shechem, who had compromised the purity of their faith. By Jesus' day, the enmity between Jews and Samaritans was intense (Luke 10:29 – 37). This slur likely had become a curse, much like "heretic" or "unbeliever," so Jesus does not even take the time to refute it. [...] The charge of demon-possession is far more serious (cf. also John 7:20; 8:52; 10:20). Rather than seeing God's work in Jesus, his opponents now point to Satan. Note that this charge appears in the Synoptic Gospels as well, where Jesus considers the glib confusing of God and Satan to be serious and unforgivable (Mark 3:22 – 27). [1]

"The climax of the entire chapter arrives at 8:58: '"I tell you the truth," Jesus answered, "before Abraham was born, I am!"' The seriousness of this statement is confirmed by Jesus' preface (lit.): 'Truly, truly [Gk. *amen, amen*] I say to you,' a phrase Jesus uses some twenty times in the Gospel (see comment on 1:51). This is an absolute claim to preexistence anchored in the absolute 'I am' (Gk. *ego eimi*) language we have already seen in this Gospel (cf. 4:26). 'I am' possesses no predicate (as in 'I am the bread of life,' 6:35) and so stands alone, no doubt echoing the Greek translation of God's divine name given in Exodus 3:14. To exist before the birth of Abraham — and yet to stand here today — is the boldest claim Jesus has yet made.

"This reflex that cannot see God in the prophetic voice of Jesus, that rebels and fights and attacks, is the work of Satan (8:45). It is Satan's work among religious people. It is a work that appeared within Judaism and that appears just as often within the Christian church. It is the work of darkness that is commonplace to the human heart. It is work that denies the true authority of the Son and robs him of his credentials to speak (8:13). It is work that puts Jesus before the bar of secular examination, when the examiners are discovered to be philosophers or theologians or historians (8:15). It is work that refuses to admit that his voice is not merely another human voice, but a divine voice sent by God (8:26 – 27, 40). It is work that distorts the truth, that lies about what it knows to be real, and that defends instead its own religious prerogatives (8:44). Above all, it is a voice that makes a human voice preeminent to the voice of God."[2]

1 Burge, Gary M. "John 7:53 – 8:11" In The NIV Application Commentary: John *(Grand Rapids, MI: Zondervan Publishing House, 2000), 237-252.*
2 Ibid.

Bible Text: John 8:1-11 (ESV)

John 8:3-9

- What caused the accusers to go away "one by one, beginning with the older ones"? What would have been the accusers' view of themselves as they came? What would have been their view as they left? What did they miss?
- How did the teachers of the law and the Pharisees treat the woman caught in adultery? How did Jesus treat her? What can I learn about Jesus from this? How does this give me courage to come to Jesus with my sins?

John 8:10-11

- How have I personally experienced the words "Neither do I condemn you; go, and from now on sin no more"?

Journal

Please use one of the prompts below to get your journaling started.

- Recall a significant reaction, conversation or event.
- Explore your fears and what's behind them.
- Write about a relational conflict you are experiencing.
- List out all that you are grateful for.

Bible Text: John 8:12-30 (ESV)

John 8:12-13

- Reflect on Jesus' words: "I am the light of the world. Whoever follows me will not walk in darkness, but will have the light of life."
- How has following Jesus led me out of darkness and into the "light of life"?

John 8:23-28

- Reflect on the anguished heart with which Jesus would have spoken v. 24: "I told you that you would die in your sins, for unless you believe that I am he you will die in your sins."
- What about the cross (where Jesus was "lifted up") causes people to know that Jesus is indeed the one he claimed to be (v. 28)?

Tuesday, January 20, 2026

Journal

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- Recall a significant reaction, conversation or event.
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- List out all that you are grateful for.

Bible Text: John 8:31-47 (ESV)

John 8:31-36

- Most people would say, as the people did in v. 33, "We...have never been enslaved to anyone." In what ways are people today enslaved?
- How has Jesus set me free from being "a slave to sin"?

John 8:37, 43-44, 47

- Jesus is addressing those who have already decided to kill him. What is the reason for their rejection of Jesus? How does Jesus' warning—that the issue is not a lack of clarity but their hostile relationship with truth—apply today? Are there times I have found spiritual issues confusing because my desires have clouded the truth?

John 8:44-46

- Consider the sobering statement here about lying. How am I challenged about my speech?

Journal

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- Recall a significant reaction, conversation or event.
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Bible Text: John 8:48-59 (ESV)

John 8:55

- From the two ways Jesus describes his relationship with the Father, what can I learn about what constitutes a relationship with God? Contrast this to the Jews' notion of what it meant to belong to God.

John 8:48-59

- The ongoing battle between Jesus and the Jews throughout this chapter boils down to the issue of who Jesus is and who they are. What are their differing answers to these two questions?
- What is the significance of Jesus' claim in v. 58? Where do I stand on this question of Jesus' identity?

Journal

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- Recall a significant reaction, conversation or event.
- Explore your fears and what's behind them.
- Write about a relational conflict you are experiencing.
- List out all that you are grateful for.

Memory Verse

John 8:12 (ESV)

Again Jesus spoke to them, saying, "I am the light of the world. Whoever follows me will not walk in darkness, but will have the light of life."

Journal

Please use one of the prompts below to get your journaling started.

- Recall a significant reaction, conversation or event.
- Explore your fears and what's behind them.
- Write about a relational conflict you are experiencing.
- List out all that you are grateful for.

Commentary on John 9

vv. 1-7 "The man whom Jesus meets at the Feast of Tabernacles has been blind from birth (9:1). This leads his disciples to ask about the origin of his suffering (9:2). They assume there must be a connection between sin and suffering, so they probe who is responsible, the man or his parents. Jesus rejects this entire line of questioning (9:3).

"The 'purpose clause' of 9:3b ('so that the work of God ... ') can just as well be applied to 9:4, and no doubt it should. Such clauses (introduced by Gk. *hina*) may begin the main sentence rather than follow it. Of eleven uses of the Gk. *all' hina* ('but so that,' 9:3b) in John, four of them precede their main sentence (1:31; 13:18; 14:31; 15:25). If 9:2 – 4 follows this pattern, we may translate it as follows: ' "Neither this man nor his parents sinned," said Jesus. "But so that the work of God might be displayed in his life, we must do the work of him who sent me while it is still day." '

"The purpose clause now explains that Jesus must work so that God's work may be displayed in this man's life. God had not made the man blind in order to show his glory; rather, God has sent Jesus to do works of healing in order to show his glory."[3]

vv. 8-34 "Each of these scenes probes the identity of Jesus, and each betrays a deeper literary function. As the story progresses, Jesus is more closely revealed by name: He is 'Jesus' (9:10), then he is called a 'prophet' (9:17), then 'the Christ' (9:22), and finally, he is declared to be 'from God' (9:33). It is easy to see the Christological progression of each name as the story develops. While the Pharisees repudiate Jesus and his role, the discussion drives home his true identity.

"Nevertheless the interrogation ends with the healed man experiencing the very thing his parents feared: He is expelled from the synagogue."[4]

vv. 35-41 "The story closes with Jesus' return visit to the now-healed blind man. He has heard that as a result of the healing this man was expelled from the synagogue community. Jesus similarly 'found' the paralytic in chapter 5 following his healing on the Sabbath (5:14). But while the paralytic's disobedience to Jesus in refusing to remain silent led to Jesus' increased persecution, the blind man becomes a model of faith and goodness.

"The blind man thus becomes a model of every believer who embraces Jesus' lordship and suffers persecution as a result (15:18 – 16:4).

"It is significant that John's story moves quickly away from the sheer fact of Jesus' miracle-working capacity to the identity of the One who heals. The man's faith is not in the miracle-working ability of Jesus. This is only the springboard. His faith quickly connects with the true identity of who Jesus is. He is 'the Lord,' and he rightly ought to be worshiped."[5]

3 Burge, Gary M. "John 9:1 – 41" In The NIV Application Commentary: John *(Grand Rapids, MI: Zondervan Publishing House, 2000), 269-284.*
4 Ibid.
5 Ibid.

Bible Text: John 9:1-12 (ESV)

John 9:2-3

- What kind of worldview is represented by the disciples' question in v. 2? Are there ways I can relate to this view of sin, God, and life's circumstances?
- How does Jesus' response clarify this issue? How can I respond to painful aspects of my past or my life today so that "the works of God might be displayed" in my life?

John 9:4-5

- What is the significance of these phrases: "while it is day" and "night is coming"? What are some windows of opportunity currently open to me? In what ways, and to whom, can I bring healing and Jesus' light?

John 9:6-7

- What can I learn about obedience and blessing from the fact that this man obeyed despite his limited knowledge?

Journal

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- Recall a significant reaction, conversation or event.
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- Write about a relational conflict you are experiencing.
- List out all that you are grateful for.

Bible Text: John 9:8-23 (ESV)

John 9:8-17

- After the healing, the man finds himself alienated from his neighbors and in trouble with the authorities. What can we make of this turn of events?
- What implication does this have on what a new Christian can expect from those who knew him before?

John 9:18-23

- In what ways is this scene of the parents' interrogation reflective of our world today where it's "already agreed that if anyone should confess Jesus to be Christ" they would "be put out" of the circle? What are some examples of such circles?
- Is there some way I can relate to the parents' noncommittal response?

Journal

Please use one of the prompts below to get your journaling started.

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- List out all that you are grateful for.

Bible Text: John 9:11-41 (ESV)

John 9:11-38

- What is the progression of how the man refers to Jesus (vv. 11, 17, 33, 38)?
- How have I experienced this kind of progression in my understanding of who God is throughout my spiritual journey?
- How did the harsh interrogation of the man and his vigorous defense of Jesus before the Pharisees play a role in strengthening his faith? What are some lessons for me?
- How does the man manage to remain unshaken by the religious leaders' intimidation and interrogation? How am I challenged by the man's clear and simple testimony (v. 25)? What can I learn about the power of personal witness?

Journal

Please use one of the prompts below to get your journaling started.

- Recall a significant reaction, conversation or event.
- Explore your fears and what's behind them.
- Write about a relational conflict you are experiencing.
- List out all that you are grateful for.

Commentary on John 10

vv. 1-6 "Jesus assumes his audience understands the scene he is constructing. In the desert at night sheep were often herded into walled enclosures that either backed up against a cliff face or were at the end of a canyon. Such enclosures (still used today by Palestinian shepherds in the Judean desert) had waist-high stone walls topped with thorny branches. Such a pen was entirely for safety so that the sheep would not become prey to wild animals. One small doorway (or opening) in the wall served as the only entrance and exit. The shepherd would either close this area with dry thorn bushes or would himself serve as sentry in the opening.

"Not only can sheep identify rightful shepherds by their access through the main gate, but they also recognize the voice of their shepherd (10:3-5). The Middle Eastern shepherd is well known for having a personal devotion to his sheep. He talks to them and sings to them. Often shepherds will carry a short flute and use a repeated tune so that the flock has a consistent auditory cue to follow. Jesus notes that this shepherd does not simply lead any sheep but rather leads 'his own' (10:3b)."[6]

vv. 7-10 "Who are these 'thieves and robbers' who have come before Jesus (10:8)? Some have argued that they are false messiahs in the first century, and we know that there were many. But the most likely target of Jesus' criticism is the Pharisees, who have been the subject of Jesus' teaching since chapter 9. Since the Maccabean era Jerusalem had witnessed many leaders who qualified as 'false shepherds.'"[7]

vv. 11-21 "The unique love and intimacy between the Father and the Son is the model that determines the relationship of Jesus to his flock. Jesus now probes the deeper meaning of the Father's love for him (10:17–19). The fundamental element in this relationship is Jesus' dependence on and obedience to God's will. This is expressed utterly in his willingness to die on the cross. We must avoid the idea that in giving his life, the Son wins the Father's love. The Father gives everything into the Son's hands (3:35), shows him everything (5:20), gives him life (5:26), and gives his own glory (17:24) and name (17:26). Indeed, the Father has loved the Son from the 'creation of the world' (17:24). Jesus' voluntary death therefore is a hallmark of his union with the Father's will and an expression of the love they share together."[8]

vv. 22-42 "The crowd is looking for an unambiguous statement about Jesus' identity. 'How long will you keep us in suspense?' (10:24) can also be translated, 'How long will you annoy us?' Are these people seeking clarity or are they antagonistic? What they want is an open, clear statement from Jesus about his messiahship, and no doubt they are poised to judge him if his answer is not to their liking. Thus far Jesus has not made an explicit, public claim to be the Christ. He did this privately to the Samaritan woman (4:26) and the blind man (9:35-36), and many have already offered this statement of faith.

"But given the explosive, highly politicized views of the Messiah in this period, it is not surprising that Jesus has used restraint so far. He has used images in the festivals and allusions from the Old Testament. Now his audience wants a 'plain' statement (cf. 7:4, 13). But we have already learned that even if Jesus were to speak plainly, only his 'sheep' would recognize his voice (10:26). Ironically, his shepherd sermon was just such a disclosure, but they have not 'heard' it."[9]

6 Gary M. Burge, The NIV Application Commentary: John *(Grand Rapids, MI: Zondervan Publishing House, 2000), 284-308.*
7 Ibid.
8 Ibid.
9 Ibid.

Bible Text: John 10:1-11 (ESV)

John 10:3-5

- Reflect on the words "the sheep follow him, for they know his voice." How have I grown to recognize Jesus' voice in my life?
- What are the other voices that might muffle Jesus' voice in my life?

"The sudden shift of metaphor from shepherd to gate seems rather strange to us, but in reality it is not. When the sheep returned to the fold at night after a day of grazing, the shepherd stood in the doorway of the pen and inspected each one as it entered. ... After all the sheep had been counted and brought into the pen, the shepherd lay down across the doorway so that no intruder—man or beast—could enter without his knowledge. The shepherd became the door. The emphatic singular pronoun 'I' (ego) emphasizes that the shepherd is the sole determiner of who enters the fold and who is excluded. It parallels the later statement: 'I am the way and the truth and the life. No one comes to the Father except through me' (John 14:6)."[10]

John 10:7-10

- The thief represented "all who came before" (v. 8) who claimed some authority to guide the sheep. What modern-day sources of authority tell people how to live and where to find pasture? In what ways is it accurate that the end result of such thieves' voices is to "steal and kill and destroy" people's lives?
- What would it look like for a Christian to allow Jesus to be the exclusive "door" for his life to keep "thieves and robbers" out?

10 Merrill C. Tenney, "John 10:7" in The Expositor's Bible Commentary, *rev. ed., Volume 10: Luke–Acts (Grand Rapids: Zondervan Pub. House, 2007).*

Journal

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- Recall a significant reaction, conversation or event.
- Explore your fears and what's behind them.
- Write about a relational conflict you are experiencing.
- List out all that you are grateful for.

Memory Verse

John 10:10-11 (ESV)

"The thief comes only to steal and kill and destroy. I came that they may have life and have it abundantly. I am the good shepherd. The good shepherd lays down his life for the sheep."

Journal

Please use one of the prompts below to get your journaling started.

- Recall a significant reaction, conversation or event.
- Explore your fears and what's behind them.
- Write about a relational conflict you are experiencing.
- List out all that you are grateful for.

Bible Text: John 10:10-21 (ESV)

John 10:10-15

- Reflect on the words that describe why Jesus came. In contrast to the thieves that come "only to steal and kill and destroy," how does the gospel and following Jesus lead to an "abundant life"?

John 10:10-11, 14-15

- What are the characteristics of a good shepherd vs. a hired hand?
- Reflect on the fact that, as the good shepherd, Jesus has ownership over my life. To what extent have I yielded to his claim on my life?

John 10:17-18

- Reflect on v. 18 and what this means for me personally.

Journal

Please use one of the prompts below to get your journaling started.

- Recall a significant reaction, conversation or event.
- Explore your fears and what's behind them.
- Write about a relational conflict you are experiencing.
- List out all that you are grateful for.

Bible Text: John 10:22-30 (ESV)

"The Feast of Dedication, now known as Hanukkah, was established as a memorial to the purification and rededication of the temple by Judas Maccabeus [who successfully led a revolt against foreign occupying forces and who therefore was regarded as a Messianic figure]."[11]

John 10:22-24

- Given that this happened during the Feast of Dedication, what might have motivated the Jews to ask the question about Jesus' identity?
- Why would approaching Jesus as a potential political deliverer from the Roman occupiers eventually lead to anger and rejection? How does this dynamic play out in people's approach toward God in our day?

John 10:27-29

- What are the characteristics of Jesus' sheep?
- How do Jesus' words—"no one will snatch them out of my hand"—encourage me in my struggles today?

11 Frank E. Gaebelein, Gen. Ed. Expositor's Bible Commentary CD *(Grand Rapids: Zondervan Pub. House, 1992), notes for John chapter 10.*

Journal

Please use one of the prompts below to get your journaling started.

- Recall a significant reaction, conversation or event.
- Explore your fears and what's behind them.
- Write about a relational conflict you are experiencing.
- List out all that you are grateful for.

Bible Text: John 10:31-42 (ESV)

John 10:31-42

- Jesus' "many good works" were met with acceptance, while his claim to "make [himself] God" elicited a violent response. In what ways does this parallel people's responses to Jesus today?
- Contrast the people's response in vv. 41-42 with the response of the Jews in vv. 19-21, 24, 31-34, 39.
- What is behind this desire to separate Jesus' good works from his claims about who he is?
- Are there some ways I can relate to the desire to separate aspects of Jesus that are widely accepted (his kindness, high ethics, etc.) from his claims to divinity?

Journal

Please use one of the prompts below to get your journaling started.

- Recall a significant reaction, conversation or event.
- Explore your fears and what's behind them.
- Write about a relational conflict you are experiencing.
- List out all that you are grateful for.

Commentary on John 11

vv. 1-16 "When Jesus hears the report about Lazarus' illness, his response (11:4) parallels his comments about the man born blind (9:1-5). The final result of this tragedy is that God will be glorified, not that death will win the victory. It is not a denial of Lazarus' death since this is the thrust of the whole story, but that death will not gain the final word in this man's life. The tragedy is not by God's design, but God will use it for an opportunity to glorify his Son."[12]

vv. 17-37 "When Jesus finally arrives in Bethany, Lazarus has been dead for four days. This note is significant. There was a well-known Jewish belief (attested from about A.D. 200) that the soul of a dead person remained in the vicinity of the body 'hoping to reenter it' for three days, but once decomposition set in, the soul departed. John wants us to know clearly that Lazarus is truly dead and that the miracle of Jesus cannot be construed as a resuscitation."[13]

vv. 38-44 "As Jesus steps to the tomb itself (11:38), he is 'once more deeply moved.' The verb used here is the same one as in 11:33 (*embrimaomai*), which suggests he is outraged at what he sees. The Lord of life is now directly confronting his opponent, death, symbolized in the cave-tomb before him.

"The dramatic high point of the story is reached in 11:43 when Jesus calls t`o Lazarus 'in a loud voice' to come out. This is not a whisper or a firm request. It is a shout of raw authority. The Greek *kraugazo* [to cry out; to exclaim] is used six times in John — in addition to here, once for the crowds on Palm Sunday (12:13) and four times for the cries of the crowds calling for Jesus' crucifixion (18:40; 19:6, 12, 15). When Lazarus emerges from the tomb, he is bound in grave wrappings, which were strips of fabric wound around his limbs and filled with burial spices. Jewish burials likewise tied the jaw closed and covered the face with a linen cloth.

"Lazarus' coming from the grave must have been an amazing spectacle witnessed by a growing crowd of people, many of whom carry news of this miracle back to Jerusalem (12:9, 17)."[14]

vv. 45-57 "The Sanhedrin deliberations (11:47–50) are noteworthy. (1) There is genuine fear that the populace will accept Jesus as the Messiah. This is not simply religious rivalry, but a paralyzing concern that if a messianic claimant is embraced by the city, the Roman armies will suppress it. 'Our place' (11:48) refers to the Jerusalem temple (NRSV, 'our holy place'; cf. Acts 6:13 – 14; 7:7; 21:28). The Romans had shown their intolerance to this sort of messianism in the past (viewing it as a political challenge), and Jerusalem's leadership know the seriousness of the threat now."[15]

vv. 1-57 "We should see this chapter as an important statement about the character of Jesus' work. John includes this story so that Jesus' message does not 'sink into a general symbolic mysticism.' His works are concrete. He is not just the light; he gives sight to a blind man. Jesus is not just the resurrection and the life; he brings a man from the tomb. The revelation of Jesus does not take place apart from concrete acts in history.

"But we are given advance notice that this death is not going to be a tragedy. What Jesus can do for Lazarus by opening the Bethany tomb is now foreshadowing what he can do for himself. The tomb that cannot contain Lazarus cannot hold him either. Moreover, we are told that the death of Jesus is not simply an obstacle to be overcome by resurrection. Caiaphas tells us that Jesus' death will be purposeful. Jesus will die for the people and the nation (11:50). Jesus will give life only by giving his own life.

"In some respects, we also live in an age that does its best to deny death. People rarely die at home surrounded by their loved ones. Their bodies are no longer 'dressed' and prepared for burial by the family (as they were not too many decades ago). Today this process has been sanitized, taken over by professional hospitals, hospices, and morticians. As a result, few of us have seen someone die, and I dare say that before the twentieth century there were few who had not seen someone die. We build coffins that look like plush, oversized jewelry boxes and cemeteries that evoke the peace and serenity of a botanical garden. We use euphemisms ('Mrs. Taylor passed away on Tuesday') to gloss over what we dare not say. All of this is cultural, springing from the heartfelt wish to make death pleasant. But it masks a profound anxiety that even the prettiest funeral service cannot disguise.

12 Gary M. Burge, "John 11:1–57" In The NIV Application Commentary: John *(Grand Rapids, MI: Zondervan Publishing House, 2000), 308-333.*
13 Ibid.
14 Ibid.
15 Ibid.

"Perhaps this is why in the work of the church, funeral services become such potent opportunities for ministry. Here the raw vulnerability of our lives stands naked and we are confronted by a personal fate we would rather not look at directly. The story of Lazarus draws us directly into the pathos so deeply rooted in our hearts.

"While the chief thrust of chapter 11 is theological, the dramatic setting of the story also invites reflection. [...] In some Christian circles Jesus' power over the grave is embraced with such conviction that there is no permission to mourn the tragedy of death. To grieve is to show a lack of faith; funerals are to be celebrations of eternal life and victory. To a degree this is true, but it denies a basic human need to express the sorrow and dismay that comes with loss. One obvious thing about John's story is a thing we may pass over quickly: Martha and Mary were crying. Jesus did not say to Martha, 'If you believe in the resurrection, why are you wasting your time and your tears?' He did not say to Mary, 'If you have victorious faith, you should stand clear-eyed and confident because I am here.' No. Jesus did not impede this family's grieving; instead by joining with them, he gives generous permission. It is right to describe death as terrible and painful and horrible without compromising the quality of our faith. Jesus himself cried in anger at the wreckage death brought to one family. Death is a foe that in Christ is being defeated."[16]

16 Ibid.

Bible Text: John 11:1-16 (ESV)

John 11:1-6

- What are some ways God has redeemed painful experiences in my life "for the glory of God, so that the Son of God may be glorified through [them]"?
- Are there seemingly hopeless situations in my life currently through which Jesus may be glorified?

John 11:14-15

- Jesus said he was glad at how events turned out "so that you may believe." What can we learn about the nature of believing, given that Jesus was talking to his disciples who had been following him all along and already believed in him?

John 11:8, 12, 16

- The disciples seemed preoccupied with safety concerns (v. 8), and then misunderstood Jesus (v. 12) and the situation (v. 16). Think about the role of fear in affecting people's perception of reality or in hearing God's word accurately. What are some fears that may be having a similar effect on my life right now?

Journal

Please use one of the prompts below to get your journaling started.

- Recall a significant reaction, conversation or event.
- Explore your fears and what's behind them.
- Write about a relational conflict you are experiencing.
- List out all that you are grateful for.

Memory Verse

John 10:27-28 (ESV)

"My sheep hear my voice, and I know them, and they follow me. I give them eternal life, and they will never perish, and no one will snatch them out of my hand."

Journal

Please use one of the prompts below to get your journaling started.

- Recall a significant reaction, conversation or event.
- Explore your fears and what's behind them.
- Write about a relational conflict you are experiencing.
- List out all that you are grateful for.

Bible Text: John 11:17-37 (ESV)

John 11:25

- Reflect on Jesus' statement in v. 25. What are the implications of living with the belief that Jesus is "the resurrection and the life"?

John 11:33-36

- How did Jesus react when he saw Mary and the Jews weeping for Lazarus? What can we make of Jesus' reaction, given he already knew he would raise Lazarus from the dead (v. 11)?
- What common view of God does v. 35 challenge?

Journal

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- List out all that you are grateful for.

Bible Text: John 11:38-44 (ESV)

John 11:39-41

- Jesus told the people gathered there to "take away the stone." How is Martha's response relatable when thinking about what God can do in my life or in the lives of others?
- What lessons are there for me as I consider this passage?

John 11:43-44

- What two things did Jesus command, first to Lazarus and then to the others?
- How have I responded to both commands to "come out" and be "unbound"?

Journal

Please use one of the prompts below to get your journaling started.

- Recall a significant reaction, conversation or event.
- Explore your fears and what's behind them.
- Write about a relational conflict you are experiencing.
- List out all that you are grateful for.

Bible Text: John 11:45-57 (ESV)

John 11:45-53

- What were the two drastically different responses of those who witnessed Jesus raising Lazarus from the dead?
- What was the real motivation behind the chief priests' and Pharisees' opposition to Jesus (v. 48)?
- To what extent is it true to this day that people resist Jesus mainly because he threatens their autonomy and security?

John 11:49-52

- Caiaphas the high priest unwittingly prophesied that Jesus "would die for the nation." What can I learn about how God works from the fact that, even though Caiaphas was faithless, God was faithful to the office of high priest till the end?

Journal

Please use one of the prompts below to get your journaling started.

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- Explore your fears and what's behind them.
- Write about a relational conflict you are experiencing.
- List out all that you are grateful for.

Commentary on John 12

vv. 1-11 "It goes without saying that Mary's dramatic gesture (which fits her portrait in Luke 10:38-42) is astonishing. While Judas objects (12:4), Jesus finds in it a pleasing expression of devotion. Nard was a rare and precious spice imported from northern India.

"A pound of the spice would have been huge and lavish. Its value of three hundred denarii represents one year's wage for a day-laborer (Matt. 20:1-16). Some cheaper nard cost one hundred denarii per pound (depending on its origin: Gaul, Crete, or Syria), but our story shows that Mary has purchased the very best.

"The quantity is so great that the entire house is filled with its fragrance (John 12:3), which underscores the extravagance of the gift. John emphasizes Jesus' feet to show the sheer act of humble devotion on Mary's part and to provide a contrast with the foot-washing of the next chapter."[17]

vv. 12-19 "The branches from date palms (12:13) were abundant in Israel, and their use here is important for symbolic reasons. Palms had become a symbol of Jewish nationalism. When the temple was rededicated during the Maccabean era, palms were used in the celebration (1 Macc. 13:51; 2 Macc. 10:7). In the extrabiblical tradition, palms were used by Levi as a symbol of ruling power (T. Naph. 5:4). During both major wars with Rome, reliefs of palms were stamped on the coins minted by the rebels. Thus this act of celebration is by no means neutral. It symbolizes Israel's national hopes, now focused on Jesus, being hailed as he enters the city.

"The cry of 'Hosanna!' is an Aramaic phrase meaning 'Save us now!' and it occurs in a number of the psalms (esp. Ps. 118:25). The following words ('Blessed is he who comes in the name of the Lord') likewise continue to quote from Psalm 118:26 and announce a blessing on the pilgrim arriving in Jerusalem. But what comes next ('Blessed is the king of Israel!') is not in the psalm and departs considerably from its intent. Suddenly we gain the impression that the crowds are greeting a national liberator.

"The crowd is cheering a fantasy: Their messianic hero is a victor bringing a triumphant messianism to Jerusalem. But Jesus is a humble servant, and I imagine he wondered a great deal about the source of these people's zeal. Nevertheless, here we have celebration. For John, even if players in his story do not know the deeper meaning of their actions (e.g., Caiaphas in 11:51), John is willing to identify the error and permit us to see the double meaning. Jerusalem is celebrating the arrival of its king despite the erroneous motivations of Jewish nationalists on that day.

"Palm Sunday is a happy day, a day of flowers and dresses and new shoes. But another message carries a warning about our vision of Jesus as we celebrate. The crowd in Jerusalem had many who understood both the needs of the day and the charismatic power of Jesus. In some fashion (which perhaps they did not entirely understand) they assumed that Jesus and his movement would serve their cause. Their vision for society and Jesus' presence could together make changes they dearly desired. As the gospel story unfolds further, Jesus' failure to satisfy those visions (religious, political, and social) leads to a cry for crucifixion one week later."[18]

vv. 20-36 "Curiously, the arrival of these God-fearers triggers 'the hour' we have been hearing about throughout the gospel (12:23). Many times we have listened to Jesus say that the hour has not yet arrived (2:4; 7:30; 8:20). [...] Therefore something has changed; the Greeks signal the closing of a chapter for Jesus. His ministry in Judaism is finished and he now belongs to the wider world.

"Rather than engage these God-fearers (who now disappear from the story), Jesus offers an extended discourse (12:24 – 36) that gives insight into the meaning of this hour. What are the chief elements here? Jesus begins by offering a parable that explains the 'law of the kingdom of God.' Just as a seed must 'die' in order to give life, likewise Jesus must die in order to give life to the world. This same law applies to disciples (12:25). To relinquish one's hold on life — to give it up — is the key to participation in the kingdom."[19]

vv. 42-50 "The Book of Signs closes with Jesus' making a final plea for belief, probably in the precincts of the temple. For John this is no doubt a final theological summary, comprising the main motifs that have been publicly revealed in the ministry of Jesus. [...] But we also have a warning. Just as Moses' word will judge Israel (5:45), so now Jesus' word will remain as a deposit of revelation by which human lives may be judged (12:48). Moreover, discipleship is not just a matter of knowing Jesus' word; it is also a matter of 'keeping' and 'doing' what Jesus has said (12:47; cf. 8:31; Matt. 7:24 – 27; James 2:14 – 26)."[20]

17 Gary M. Burge, "John 12:1–50" In The NIV Application Commentary: John *(Grand Rapids, MI: Zondervan Publishing House, 2000), 333-361.*
18 Ibid.
19 Ibid.
20 Ibid.

Bible Text: John 12:1-8 (ESV)

"Spices and ointments were quite costly because they had to be imported. Frequently they were used as an investment because they occupied a small space, were portable, and were easily negotiable in the open market. Mary's offering was valued at three hundred denarii (v. 5) approximately a year's wages for an ordinary workingman. Perhaps it represented her life savings. [...] Wiping his feet with her hair was a gesture of utmost devotion and reverence. The penetrative fragrance of the ointment that filled the house told all present of her sacrificial gift."[21]

- Reflect on Mary's outpouring of this expensive perfume. In what ways was this appropriate given what Jesus was about to do (vv. 23-24)?
- What fundamental difference between Mary and Judas is revealed by his objection to what she did?
- Think about the progression of Judas' actions: "he used to help himself" to the communal money and was now "about to betray [Jesus]."
- Judas expressed outrage in pretending to care for the poor. How might things have changed for Judas if he had been honest about what was going on in his heart?

21 Frank E. Gaebelein, Gen. Ed. Expositor's Bible Commentary CD *(Grand Rapids: Zondervan Pub. House, 1992), notes for John chapter 12.*

Journal

Please use one of the prompts below to get your journaling started.

- Recall a significant reaction, conversation or event.
- Explore your fears and what's behind them.
- Write about a relational conflict you are experiencing.
- List out all that you are grateful for.

Memory Verse

John 11:25 (ESV)

Jesus said to her, "I am the resurrection and the life. Whoever believes in me, though he die, yet shall he live."

Journal

Please use one of the prompts below to get your journaling started.

- Recall a significant reaction, conversation or event.
- Explore your fears and what's behind them.
- Write about a relational conflict you are experiencing.
- List out all that you are grateful for.

Bible Text: John 12:9-19 (ESV)

John 12:9-11, 17-19

- What lessons can I learn about human nature from the absurdity of the chief priests' plan to put Lazarus to death?

"'Hosanna' is a Hebrew expression meaning literally 'Save now!' It may be interpreted as a plea for immediate action on the part of the king (John 12:13)."[22]

"There is no doubt at all that Jesus' claim was a messianic claim. [...] The point is that a king came riding upon a horse when he was bent on war; he came riding upon [a donkey] when he was coming in peace. This action of Jesus is a sign that he was not the warrior figure men dreamed of, but the Prince of Peace. No one saw it at that time, not even the disciples, who should have known so much better."[23]

John 12:12-19

- When the crowd cried out those words in v.13, what picture did they have in mind of who Jesus was and what he would do?
- What was the truth of who Jesus was and what he came to save people from? Are there ways I can relate to the crowd and their expectations of Jesus?
- When were the disciples able to understand fully all that was taking place?
- Why is the death and resurrection of Jesus the key to understanding the person of Jesus?

22 Frank E. Gaebelein, Gen. Ed. Expositor's Bible Commentary CD *(Grand Rapids: Zondervan Pub. House, 1992), notes for John chapter 12.*
23 William Barclay, The Gospel of John (Vol. 2), The Daily Study Bible Series *(Louisville, KY.: Westminster John Knox Press, 1975), 118.*

Journal

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- Recall a significant reaction, conversation or event.
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- List out all that you are grateful for.

Bible Text: John 12:20-26 (ESV)

John 12:20-26

- Reflect on the link between glory and becoming "a grain of wheat [that] falls into the earth and dies" as it applies to Jesus' life. How does the Christian understanding of glory differ from the world's definition? In what ways have I embraced the life of becoming a grain of wheat that falls and dies?
- What are the ways in which people "lose" their life because they "love" it too much?
- In what ways am I challenged to use up my life rather than to cling onto it?

John 12:26

- Reflect on the call and promise contained in this verse. What is my response to this call and promise?

Journal

Please use one of the prompts below to get your journaling started.

- Recall a significant reaction, conversation or event.
- Explore your fears and what's behind them.
- Write about a relational conflict you are experiencing.
- List out all that you are grateful for.

Bible Text: John 12:23-36a (ESV)

John 12:25-28

- Reflect on Jesus' words: "But for this purpose I have come to this hour." How does Jesus' prayer demonstrate what it means to live out v. 25?

John 12:30-36

- Recall v. 24 and how Jesus refused to remain a single seed that does not die. How does Jesus willingly laying down his life cast out the "ruler of this world"?
- In what ways am I still listening to the "ruler of this world"?
- Reflect on how v. 32 has worked out in history and in my life.

Journal

Please use one of the prompts below to get your journaling started.

- Recall a significant reaction, conversation or event.
- Explore your fears and what's behind them.
- Write about a relational conflict you are experiencing.
- List out all that you are grateful for.

Bible Text: John 12:36b-50 (ESV)

"God appointed the prophet to preach to the inhabitants of Judah but warned him in advance that his mission would not be successful. The verbs as given in Isaiah 6:9-10 are imperatives. Isaiah was told to announce his message even though it merely hardened the hearts of those who heard him. God offered the opportunity of faith, but the very offer made the recipients of it more obstinate. John interprets the prophecy by its effect rather than by its intention. It was not God's desire to alienate his people; but without the offer of faith and repentance, they would never turn to him anyway. The cumulative effect of unbelief is a hardened attitude that becomes more impenetrable as time progresses."[24]

John 12:37-40

- What was the reason the Jews could not believe in Jesus despite all the miraculous signs he had done?
- How can continuing to see the work of God and yet refusing to believe cause a person to become blinded and hardened?

John 12:42-43

- What was the dilemma for these leaders who would not confess their faith "for fear of the Pharisees [...] so that they would not be put out of the synagogue"?

John 12:47-50

- What has been my attitude toward the word of God that "is eternal life" when believed, but which "will judge [me] on the last day" if rejected?

24 Frank E. Gaebelein, Gen. Ed. Expositor's Bible Commentary CD *(Grand Rapids: Zondervan Pub. House, 1992), notes for John chapter 12.*

Journal

Please use one of the prompts below to get your journaling started.

- Recall a significant reaction, conversation or event.
- Explore your fears and what's behind them.
- Write about a relational conflict you are experiencing.
- List out all that you are grateful for.

Memory Verse

John 12:24-25 (ESV)

"Truly, truly, I say to you, unless a grain of wheat falls into the earth and dies, it remains alone; but if it dies, it bears much fruit. Whoever loves his life loses it, and whoever hates his life in this world will keep it for eternal life."

Journal

Please use one of the prompts below to get your journaling started.

- Recall a significant reaction, conversation or event.
- Explore your fears and what's behind them.
- Write about a relational conflict you are experiencing.
- List out all that you are grateful for.

Commentary on John 13

vv. 1-17 "The task of footwashing was so menial that according to some Jewish sources, Jewish slaves were exempt and the job kept for Gentiles. [...] At the very least, all our ancient sources show that footwashing was a degrading and lowly task. When done by a wife (for her husband), a child (for his/her parents), or a pupil (for his teacher), it was always an act of extreme devotion. But since it was an act with social implications, in no way do we find those with a 'higher' status washing the feet of those beneath them. When Jesus 'takes off his outer clothing' and wraps a towel around himself (13:4), he is adopting the posture of a slave.

"While the circle of disciples seems to accept Jesus' gesture (13:5), Peter reflects how shocking the deed must have seemed (13:6). The depth of his devotion to Jesus defines the strength of his objection. But Jesus is not simply giving them a lesson in humble service (this will come in 13:14); he is doing something that symbolizes his greater act of sacrifice on the cross (13:7). Only after 'the hour' when Jesus is resurrected will any of this make sense (cf. 2:22; 12:16). But Peter continues to object in the most strenuous way, and Jesus' rebuke is carefully worded. 'If I do not wash you ...' means that the question is not simply one of washing, but a question of who does the washing. Peter must participate in the work of Jesus (13:8 – 9). He lacks a cleansing that only Jesus can supply.

"The curious return to the subject of Judas in 13:10b – 11 (cf. 13:2) indicates that Jesus' work of footwashing has not changed Judas's heart. The fact alone that Jesus washed Judas's feet is stunning and is a testimony to Jesus' patience and love for his followers (even the man who betrays him).

"Jesus' act was powerful not because of the footwashing itself, but because of the role he was assuming by doing it. To sweep a floor is commonplace, but for Queen Elizabeth of England to come and sweep my kitchen would be upsetting, not because sweeping is significant but because the Queen is doing it. It is the person of Jesus tied to this lowly role that brings power to this image."[25]

"The command to love. He wants his followers to show a quality of love unparalleled in the world. Carson puts it well: 'At the risk of confounding logic, it is not so much that Christians are to love the world less, as that they are to love one another more. Better put, their love for each other ought to be a reflection of their new status and experience as the children of God.' The theme of community love, while not compromising our commitments to the world, matches another perspective in John concerning the world."[26]

vv. 18-30 "To 'eat bread' is a cultural symbol that refers to personal intimacy, and to expose the bottom of the foot is another symbol of personal contempt. Jesus possesses divine wisdom into these events and yet experiences bewildering dismay as they unfold.

"The departure of Judas is 'at night' (13:30). No doubt we should see this as both literal and symbolic. Night represents the antithesis of Jesus, who is the light. It is the darkness of unbelief and opposition (9:4), where people stumble (11:9) and find themselves in a fruitless search for life (21:3). It is the setting of Nicodemus, a man who must choose to leave the darkness and be reborn to join Jesus (3:2; 19:39). Therefore Judas represents a person described in 3:19: 'Light has come into the world, but men loved darkness instead of light because their deeds were evil' (cf. also Luke 22:53, where Jesus describes the moment in the Garden of Gethsemane as the time 'when darkness reigns').

"Judas is a parable and a warning. We read his story as 'insiders,' thinking it depicts someone else. But Judas is a more disturbing figure than Pilate or Caiaphas or any of the Jewish leaders. He saw the light and understood it, but chose the darkness anyway. 'Judas is the reminder that every day is judgment day and that on any day some faithful follower, like Judas — or like you and me — might turn tail on the light and stumble out into the darkness, caught up in evil or caught up by evil's prince.'"[27]

25 Gary M. Burge, "John 13:1–38" In The NIV Application Commentary: John *(Grand Rapids, MI: Zondervan Publishing House, 2000), 361-388.*
26 Ibid.
27 Ibid.

Bible Text: John 13:1-20 (ESV)

John 13:1-5

- What can we learn from the fact that Jesus chose this as his final lesson for his disciples?

"This was a world where roads were dusty and sandals were worn daily. [...] The task of foot-washing was so menial that according to some Jewish sources, Jewish slaves were exempt ..."[28]

John 13:6-9

- What may have been going on in Peter's mind as he refused Jesus' offer to wash his feet?
- What are some ways people respond to Jesus like Peter did? What can I learn about what it means to have a personal relationship with Jesus?

John 13:12-17

- How seriously have I taken the call to follow Jesus' example of concrete humility and loving service for his disciples? In what ways has following Jesus' example led to blessing in my life?

28 Gary M. Burge, The NIV Application Commentary: John *(Grand Rapids, MI: Zondervan Publishing House, 2000), 368-369.*

Journal

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Bible Text: John 13:21-30 (ESV)

"'Troubled' is the same verb used of Jesus' agitation at the grave of Lazarus (11:33) and at the request of the Greeks to see him (12:21). As 'the hour' approached, the bitterness of the betrayal Jesus anticipated became known. The desertion by many of his disciples evoked an expression of disappointment; here, the injury was felt more poignantly. The quotation in 13:18, which the author cites as prophetic of Jesus' feeling, contains in its context an allusion to 'my close friend, whom I trusted' (Ps. 41:9). Among the sorrows contributing to the agony of the Cross was the voluntary and selfish defection of Judas."[29]

John 13:21

- Reflect on the fact that Jesus was "troubled in his spirit." How does this match or contrast with my view of Jesus?

John 13:27-30

- What may have been the heart of Jesus as he told Judas, "What you are going to do, do quickly"?
- Notice the progression from Satan prompting Judas (v. 2) to Satan entering into Judas (v. 27). What steps could Judas have taken to arrest the downward spiral of sin's increasing hold over his will?

29 Frank E. Gaebelein, Gen. Ed. Expositor's Bible Commentary CD *(Grand Rapids: Zondervan Pub. House, 1992), notes for John chapter 13.*

Journal

Please use one of the prompts below to get your journaling started.

- Recall a significant reaction, conversation or event.
- Explore your fears and what's behind them.
- Write about a relational conflict you are experiencing.
- List out all that you are grateful for.

Bible Text: John 13:31-35 (ESV)

John 13:31-32

- How did God glorify Jesus through his voluntary death on the cross?

"As I have loved you: The command to love wasn't new; but the extent of love just displayed by Jesus was new, as would be the display of the cross. Love was newly defined from His example."[30]

John 13:34-35

- What is the significance of this being Jesus' final commandment to his remaining eleven disciples before his crucifixion?
- How does this clarify what the purpose of my life should be?

30 David Guzik, "Bible Study Resources" (2000), http://www.enduringword.com/bible.html.

Journal

Please use one of the prompts below to get your journaling started.

- Recall a significant reaction, conversation or event.
- Explore your fears and what's behind them.
- Write about a relational conflict you are experiencing.
- List out all that you are grateful for.

Bible Text: John 13:36-38 (ESV)

John 13:36-38

- Consider Peter's heartfelt confession of devotion to Jesus. Did he mean it? What did Jesus know that Peter did not?
- How does the cross enable Peter, who would disown Jesus three times, to continue to follow Jesus eventually to his own death?
- Reflect on the frailty of human resolve, God's generous heart, and our need for grace shown through this incident.

Journal

Please use one of the prompts below to get your journaling started.

- Recall a significant reaction, conversation or event.
- Explore your fears and what's behind them.
- Write about a relational conflict you are experiencing.
- List out all that you are grateful for.

Memory Verse

John 13:34-35 (ESV)

"A new commandment I give to you, that you love one another: just as I have loved you, you also are to love one another. By this all people will know that you are my disciples, if you have love for one another."

Journal

Please use one of the prompts below to get your journaling started.

- Recall a significant reaction, conversation or event.
- Explore your fears and what's behind them.
- Write about a relational conflict you are experiencing.
- List out all that you are grateful for.

Commentary on John 14

Introduction: "Even though it is Christ who comes in each event, the best view takes 14:2-3 as a plain promise of the Second Coming. As the chapter develops, Jesus points to other returns he will make (14:18, 23), but these are separate from what he affirms here. [...] The word translated 'rooms' does not refer to the quality of the place Jesus is preparing (as in the KJV, 'mansions'). The concern on the hearts of the disciples is their loss of Jesus' fellowship. The 'room' in Greek refers to an abode, a place of residence, a place 'with your name on it.' Jesus is saying to them (and to us) that heaven is awaiting our arrival. The experience of heaven will not be merely one of bliss, but it will be one of fellowship when Jesus renews his presence with us.

"Jesus speaks openly and honestly about his departure. [...] But here in chapter 14 Jesus tells us something about his aims: He is going to prepare a place (a 'room') for us. Immediately this means that we need to have a different perspective on the 'dwellings' we possess in this world. Jesus has gone ahead of us, and there is now something ready for us. The implications of such a teaching are profound and timely.

"Philip's question (14:8) now concentrates on Jesus' last phrase. 'Lord, show us the Father and that will be enough for us.' This is perhaps a typical 'misunderstanding' that we have seen in numerous Johannine discourses. Philip does not understand that no one has seen God (1:18a). It is beyond the human capacity. Even Moses' request on Mount Sinai was refused (Ex. 33:18-23). But in Christ Philip has before him the full embodiment of God as it can be seen by humanity. Nevertheless, Jesus now says with utter clarity what Philip could not comprehend before (14:9). In seeing Jesus Philip is seeing God. This is one of the high points of John's Christology. Jesus is not simply a religious teacher or guide, nor is he simply the means to some other destination. He is also the end, the goal. He is the One in whom God can be found. The exhaustive and exclusive nature of this astonishing claim cannot be missed (cf. 10:30, 37-38)."[31]

vv. 12-17 "It is interesting that Jesus calls the Spirit another Paraclete [or advocate/counselor]. This should not be taken to mean that the Father will send 'another person, namely, a Paraclete.' First John 2:1 makes clear that John views Jesus also as a Paraclete ('But if anyone does sin, we have an *advocate* with the Father, Jesus Christ the righteous,' NRSV, italics added) Jesus is thus a Paraclete, who is now sending a second Paraclete. This means that the ongoing work of the Spirit will be a continuation of the work of Jesus during the disciples' lifetime."[32]

vv. 18-24 "But the coming of Jesus on Easter will mean more than a mere return of Jesus to life. His aim is to establish the sort of intimacy and unity he has promised throughout the discourse. The oneness he enjoys with the Father (14:20a) parallels the oneness the disciples will enjoy with him (14:20b). Thus the Easter return will be the bridge that will inaugurate the spiritual union Jesus wants with them. The call to obedience (14:21) is similar to that given in 14:15 and is a clue that Jesus is speaking of a union that will include the coming of the Spirit. This is precisely what happens when on Easter Jesus appears to them and in that setting they receive his Spirit (20:22)."[33]

vv. 25-31 "The phrase 'is greater than' suggests (in some views) that Jesus simply cannot be God in the fullest sense, so that this verse has been used to deny the divinity of Christ.

"[...] The word picture Jesus often uses to describe his life is the agent sent on a mission (17:4-5) and completing the assignments of his Sender (4:34; 5:30; 6:38-39; 9:4; 10:32, 37; 17:4). Within this agent/sender relationship, the originator of the mission has greater authority.

"This experience of the Spirit promised by Jesus also points to benefits that are truly astounding. Believers will sustain the miraculous works of Jesus (14:12), they will have intimacy with God in prayer (14:13-14), and they will recall God's word with conviction (14:25; 1 John 2:22-27) — all with the aid of the Spirit. A brief perusal of the book of Acts shows that this is exactly the profile of the earliest Christians, and it is safe to assume that this must have been the experience of the believers in John's church. Christians were reproducing not merely the work of Jesus; they were continuing the presence of Jesus in the world. Perhaps we could put it this way: As the Son incarnated the Father's presence in the world, so now the Spirit brings the Son's presence into the world through the life of the believer.

"These three themes have sweeping importance for the church today. We live in an age that is eager for spiritual experiences. John 14 provides us with guidance on how to interpret and understand them."[34]

31 Gary M. Burge, "John 14:1–31" In The NIV Application Commentary: John *(Grand Rapids, MI: Zondervan Publishing House, 2000), 388-414.*
32 Ibid.
33 Ibid.
34 Ibid.

Bible Text: John 14:1-14 (ESV)

John 14:1-4

- Reflect on the personal way Jesus anchors his promise of heaven. What is the basis of my assurance that I will be with Jesus in the Father's house?

"Jesus' reply is the ultimate foundation for a satisfactory philosophy of life. First, it is personal. He did not claim merely to know the way, the truth, and the life as a formula he could impart to the ignorant; but he actually claimed to be the answer to human problems. Jesus' solution to perplexity is not a recipe; it is a relationship with him. [...] He is the truth because he has the perfect power of making life one coherent experience irrespective of its ups and downs. He is the life because he was not subject to death but made it subject to him. He did not live with death as the ultimate end of his life; he died to demonstrate the power and continuity of his life."[35]

John 14:5-7

- Reflect on v. 6. In what ways has Jesus been the way, the truth, and the life for me?

"He wanted to impress on the disciples that he was not disbanding them in anticipation of his departure but, rather, he was expecting them to continue his work and do even greater things than he had accomplished. Such an expectation seems impossible in the light of his character and power; yet, through the power of the Spirit whom Jesus sent after his ascension, there were more converts after the initial sermon of Peter at Pentecost than are recorded for Jesus during his entire career. The influence of the infant church covered the Roman world, whereas Jesus during his lifetime never traveled outside the boundaries of Palestine. Through the disciples he multiplied his ministry after his departure. [...] The power of the disciples originated in prayer. Jesus could hardly have made more emphatic the declaration that whatever they should ask in his name, he would do... The answer is promised so that the Son may bring glory to the Father. The disciples' obedience to him will be the test of their love."[36]

John 14:12-14

- What are the things I need to ask in Jesus' name in prayer, and what are the "greater works than these" that I will do in order "that the Father may be glorified in the Son"?

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35 Frank E. Gaebelein, Expositor's Bible Commentary CD *(Grand Rapids: Zondervan Pub. House, 1992), notes for John chapter 14.*
36 Ibid.

Journal

Please use one of the prompts below to get your journaling started.

- Recall a significant reaction, conversation or event.
- Explore your fears and what's behind them.
- Write about a relational conflict you are experiencing.
- List out all that you are grateful for.

Tuesday, March 3, 2026

Bible Text: John 14:15-26 (ESV)

"Jesus in his reply did not discuss the question of post-resurrection appearances. He focused the disciples' attention on the broader revelation that would come to them through obedience to his known teaching and through the work of the Holy Spirit. The reality of Jesus' and the Father's presence would be conditioned on obedience. [...] Obedience is not, however, the condition of God's love for men but the proof of their realization of his love and of their love for him."[37]

John 14:15-26

- What is the relationship between knowing God, loving God, and obedience?
- What do I need to obey in order to grow in my knowledge of God in this season?
- What is the role of the "Helper"—"the Spirit of truth"—in a disciple's life?

37 Frank E. Gaebelein, Expositor's Bible Commentary CD *(Grand Rapids: Zondervan Pub. House, 1992), notes for John chapter 14.*

Journal

Please use one of the prompts below to get your journaling started.

- Recall a significant reaction, conversation or event.
- Explore your fears and what's behind them.
- Write about a relational conflict you are experiencing.
- List out all that you are grateful for.

Bible Text: John 14:27-31 (ESV)

John 14:27-29

- Why was Jesus able to offer his peace to the disciples in the middle of telling them about his death?
- Contrast the peace that Jesus gives and the "peace" the world gives. How have I experienced this peace from Jesus?

John 14:30-31

- How is it that the ruler of this world has no claim on Jesus?
- What is the relationship between doing as "the Father has commanded me" and freedom from the influence of "the ruler of this world"?

Journal

Please use one of the prompts below to get your journaling started.

- Recall a significant reaction, conversation or event.
- Explore your fears and what's behind them.
- Write about a relational conflict you are experiencing.
- List out all that you are grateful for.

Commentary on John 15

vv. 1-17 "In his final 'I am' saying in this Gospel, Jesus declares that he is the true vine (15:1). That is, in this ancient imagery he has taken the place of Israel as God's true planting. The new concept is that God's vineyard holds one vine and Israel must inquire if it is attached to him. No longer is Israel automatically seen as vines growing in God's vineyard. Men and women are now branches growing from one stock.

"Jesus now calls his disciples 'friends' (15:14-15) to distinguish them from servants, who do not know the deeper thoughts of their masters. What characterizes such friends is that they obey him. [...] Where true friendship exists, true disclosure (or revelation) accompanies it (15:15b). Disciples possess the word of Jesus (thanks to the Spirit, 14:25-26), and they will receive ongoing revelations of Jesus (also brought by the Spirit, 16:12-13). Disciples thus know 'God's heart.' When they therefore pray, their desires and God's will harmonize, making them participants in God's efforts in the world (15:16; cf. 15:7)."[38]

vv. 18-25 "Jesus discusses the guilt of the world in 15:22-25 by explaining that it is accountable before the revelation of God. Jesus' ministry provided both words (15:22) and works (15:24) that pointed to God. Now that they have seen and heard him, their guilt is immovable (15:24). For instance, in the story of the healed blind man (ch. 9), the Jewish leadership refused to accept the miracle as a sign from God. Yet because they claimed to see, Jesus pronounced their guilt (9:41)."[39]

vv. 26-16:4a "The promises of the Spirit in the Synoptic Gospels fit this setting precisely. Jesus says that in the midst of persecution (Matt. 10:16-18) his followers should not worry about what to say since the Spirit will speak through them (Matt. 10:19-20; Mark 13:11). The Spirit will also instruct, 'for the Holy Spirit will teach you at that time what you should say' (Luke 12:12). But there is a partnership, for '*you* also must testify' (John 15:27a, italics added). 'You' is emphatic in Greek here, underscoring that we are not permitted a passive role. The disciples are witnesses and the Spirit will bear witness; the disciples possess the historical record of Jesus' words and work ('you have been with me from the beginning,' 15:27b), and they now will be empowered as they deliver that message to the world."[40]

38 Gary M. Burge, "John 15:1–16:4a" In The NIV Application Commentary: John *(Grand Rapids, MI: Zondervan Publishing House, 2000), 414-433.*
39 Ibid.
40 Ibid.

Bible Text: John 15:1-11 (ESV)

"Pruning is necessary for any vine. Dead wood is worse than fruitlessness, for dead wood can harbor disease and decay. An untrimmed vine will develop long rambling branches that produce little fruit because most of the strength of the vine is given to growing wood. The vine-grower is concerned that the vine be healthy and productive. The caring process is a picture of the divine dealing with human life. God removes the dead wood from his church and disciplines the life of the believer so that it is directed into fruitful activity."[41]

"The connection is maintained by obedience and prayer. To remain in Christ and to allow his words to remain in oneself means a conscious acceptance of the authority of his word and a constant contact with him by prayer."[42]

John 15:1-8

- How is the relationship between the vine and the branch a particularly apt description of my relationship with God? How is fruitlessness and withering away an accurate picture of a life that does not remain in Jesus?
- What is surprising about the fact that the vinedresser prunes the "branch that does bear fruit"?
- How does the word of God "prune" or "clean" a person?
- Notice that there is no command to bear fruit, but only the command to "abide in me." What is the significance of this, and how does this apply to me?

41 Frank E. Gaebelein, Expositor's Bible Commentary CD *(Grand Rapids: Zondervan Pub. House, 1992), notes for John chapter 15.*
42 Ibid.

Journal

Please use one of the prompts below to get your journaling started.

- Recall a significant reaction, conversation or event.
- Explore your fears and what's behind them.
- Write about a relational conflict you are experiencing.
- List out all that you are grateful for.

Memory Verse

John 15:5 (ESV)

"I am the vine; you are the branches. Whoever abides in me and I in him, he it is that bears much fruit, for apart from me you can do nothing."

Journal

Please use one of the prompts below to get your journaling started.

- Recall a significant reaction, conversation or event.
- Explore your fears and what's behind them.
- Write about a relational conflict you are experiencing.
- List out all that you are grateful for.

Bible Text: John 15:12-17 (ESV)

John 15:12-15

- Reflect on v.13 and the great love demonstrated by Jesus on the cross.
- What is the difference between a "friend" and a "servant"? What responsibility do I have since Jesus has "made known to [me]" "all that [he has] heard from [the] Father"?

John 15:12, 17

- Reflect on the repeated command to love one another.

Journal

Please use one of the prompts below to get your journaling started.

- Recall a significant reaction, conversation or event.
- Explore your fears and what's behind them.
- Write about a relational conflict you are experiencing.
- List out all that you are grateful for.

Bible Text: John 15:18-27 (ESV)

John 15:18-21

- Why does the world hate Christians? How does this challenge my view of Christian life and my relationship with the world?
- What values do I hold that are "of the world"? What values do I hold that are not of the world?

John 15:22-27

- What made those who rejected Jesus guilty of sin? What responsibility do I have towards the word of God that I have heard and the works of God that I have witnessed?
- What is revealed about Jesus' heart for the world, given the fact that he commanded his disciples to bear witness about him right after he told them the world would persecute them?

Journal

Please use one of the prompts below to get your journaling started.

- Recall a significant reaction, conversation or event.
- Explore your fears and what's behind them.
- Write about a relational conflict you are experiencing.
- List out all that you are grateful for.

Commentary on John 16

Introduction: "In 16:8-11 Jesus gives another description of what the Spirit will do in this difficult relationship with the world. Let's summarize what we have seen so far. The world cannot know the Spirit-Paraclete [Spirit-Helper or Spirit-Advocate] because it does not know or love God (14:15-17). Amidst the hostilities of the world, the Spirit-Paraclete will defend believers, strengthening their witness (15:26-27) and their recollection of the things Jesus has taught (14:26). All of this is defensive. Now in 16:8-11 the Spirit-Paraclete 'passes to the attack.' As if in a court of law, the defender now becomes prosecutor and judge."[43]

vv. 16-22 "The departure of Jesus and its distress for the disciples has been a constant theme in the Upper Room. Jesus does not let them ignore the reality of his going, and in 16:16 he brings it up again: 'In a little while you will see me no more, and then after a little while you will see me.' Jesus had said almost the same thing in 14:19. Now seven times in this chapter (16:16-19) Jesus refers to 'a little while' (Gk. *mikron*), which prompts the central question of the section: 'What does he mean by saying, "In a little while..."?' (16:17a). The confusion of the disciples is understandable. In 16:10 Jesus has said that he is going to the Father and they will not see him any longer. Now he says that they will see him, and it won't be long. What can he mean? The confusion swirls through the circle of disciples from verses 17–19.

"[...] Rather, he is simply referring to his return in resurrection. He is departing from the world in his glorification and the world will no longer have access to him. When he returns in resurrection, it will be his followers' final opportunity to see him as he has always been."[44]

vv. 5-15 "The presupposition of the convicting work of the Holy Spirit is a courageous belief in the spiritual, moral, and intellectual bankruptcy of the world. The problem with most of us is that we have adapted to the world so successfully that we no longer truly believe that its systems of belief, life, and thought are wrong. Like the proverbial frog slowly cooked in a warming pot of water, we don't realize our jeopardy till it is too late."[45]

v. 33 "It is curious that Jesus here speaks of peace and trouble in the same breath. This forces us to carefully define what this peace really is. One sort of peace means the absence of all enemies; the other is freedom from anxiety while struggling with enemies. Who could not be at peace when there is no trouble? But it is the latter notion, peace within the storm, that Jesus has in mind.

"If Jesus had said, 'Have courage, I have overcome the world — and you can too,' there would be little good news for us. If a golf master nearly drives on the green from every tee and says to you, 'Have courage, I did it! You can do it too!' there is no encouragement here. If the superior student performs perfectly on an exam and says to a less-gifted friend, 'Cheer up! I did well, so can you!' such counsel only brings a sharper sense of hopelessness.

"If Jesus was simply one heroic man who achieved a superior life, if he was simply a stellar example of what we hoped to be, then he has little value for us. We have tried to overcome the world, but we have failed. Jesus' example of superior humanity simply makes my inferiority more unbearable.

"But if Jesus is more than a human; if he is indeed the Son of God who overcame the world not simply for his own sake, but for our sake as well — for all of humanity; if his victory in his life can become a victory that we enjoy, a victory extended to us when we embrace him in faith, then his triumph can become our triumph."[46]

43 Gary M. Burge, "John 16:4b–33" In The NIV Application Commentary: John *(Grand Rapids, MI: Zondervan Publishing House, 2000), 433-457.*
44 Ibid.
45 Ibid.
46 Ibid.

Bible Text: John 16:1-7 (ESV)

John 16:1-4

- Reflect on why Jesus "said all these things." What is the role of Jesus' words in keeping me steadfast?
- Reread John 13-15 with this in mind, and think about what lessons there are for me today.

Journal

Please use one of the prompts below to get your journaling started.

- Recall a significant reaction, conversation or event.
- Explore your fears and what's behind them.
- Write about a relational conflict you are experiencing.
- List out all that you are grateful for.

Bible Text: John 16:5-15 (ESV)

John 16:8-11

- How have I experienced the Holy Spirit's work of convicting me of sin, righteousness and judgment?

"Jesus told his disciples directly that the revelation to date was incomplete. They were not sufficiently mature to understand all he wished to impart. A second function of the Holy Spirit would be to lead them into the full comprehension of all he could give them."[47]

John 16:12-15

- What can I learn about Jesus from the fact that although he had so much to say to the disciples, he told them only what he knew they could bear?
- Are there situations where I need to trust that "when the Spirit of truth comes, he will guide [me] into all the truth"? How does this provide encouragement for the work God is asking us to do in ministering to people in all stages of their spiritual journey?

47 Gary M. Burge, "John 16:4b–33" In The NIV Application Commentary: John *(Grand Rapids, MI: Zondervan Publishing House, 2000), 433-457.*

Journal

Please use one of the prompts below to get your journaling started.

- Recall a significant reaction, conversation or event.
- Explore your fears and what's behind them.
- Write about a relational conflict you are experiencing.
- List out all that you are grateful for.

Memory Verse

John 15:12-13 (ESV)

"This is my commandment, that you love one another as I have loved you. Greater love has no one than this, that someone lay down his life for his friends."

Journal

Please use one of the prompts below to get your journaling started.

- Recall a significant reaction, conversation or event.
- Explore your fears and what's behind them.
- Write about a relational conflict you are experiencing.
- List out all that you are grateful for.

Bible Text: John 16:16-24 (ESV)

John 16:17-24

- In what ways do Christians today “weep and lament” while the world rejoices?
- How will our sorrow “turn into joy”? How is this joy unlike the world’s joy?
- What ought to be my perspective on present suffering?

Journal

Please use one of the prompts below to get your journaling started.

- Recall a significant reaction, conversation or event.
- Explore your fears and what's behind them.
- Write about a relational conflict you are experiencing.
- List out all that you are grateful for.

Bible Text: John 16:25-33 (ESV)

"'You will leave me all alone' reveals Jesus' disappointment and emotional tension. The sympathy and support of these men, imperfect as they were, meant much to him. Nevertheless, his chief resource was the Father, whose purpose he came to fulfill and by whose power he was able to execute it."[48]

John 16:31-33

- How could Jesus say, "Yet I am not alone," in the face of the disciples' imminent abandonment?
- Are there any situations in which I need to trust that "I am not alone, for the Father is with me"?

"Jesus imparted to his disciples the information concerning his death and his provision for them that they might be calm and confident in the face of disillusionment and apparent disaster. [...] Even in the hour of his greatest suffering he had an unshakable confidence in the victorious purpose of God. Jesus did not overlook the trial that would affect them as well as himself, for that was inevitable in a world alienated from God. He did proclaim victory over it."[49]

- What can I learn about Jesus from the fact that he told his disciples to "take heart" right after telling them about their impending failure and disloyalty?
- How do the cross and resurrection of Jesus allow me to "take heart" despite my failures?
- How does the triumph of Jesus help me to "have peace" in the midst of tribulations?

48 Frank E. Gaebelein, Expositor's Bible Commentary CD *(Grand Rapids: Zondervan Pub. House, 1992), notes for John chapter 16.*
49 Ibid.

Journal

Please use one of the prompts below to get your journaling started.

- Recall a significant reaction, conversation or event.
- Explore your fears and what's behind them.
- Write about a relational conflict you are experiencing.
- List out all that you are grateful for.

Commentary on John 17

Introduction: "Jesus prays that his followers will be kept safe 'by that name.' The idea of name is not a minor idea to Jesus. The 'name' of someone represents the totality, the inner character, of their entire person. Thus in Exodus 3:13 it is important to Moses that he know the name of God so that he can indicate to the Israelites who their Savior really is. It is no accident that throughout the Gospel Jesus not only refers to his work as empowered by God's name (John 10:25) but also that people should believe in 'his name' (1:12; 2:23; 3:18). Jesus bears the name of God, which is unveiled in the Gospel in its many 'I am' sayings. Thus, in revealing himself, he has disclosed the personhood (the name) of God to the entire world.

"(1) Jesus' first concern, his first petition for his followers, is that they remain united (17:11). Remarkably he desires that his disciples enjoy an intimacy and oneness that are analogous to the intimacy and oneness he shares with the Father.

"(2) Jesus' next worry concerns his disciples' sustenance and strength in the world. Their assignment is dangerous, and so he prays for their equipment and protection. Jesus has given them his word (17:14a), and the Spirit will recall it and keep it secure (14:26). This word, this divine revelation, will become essential equipment in their testimony and survival in the world.

"(3) Jesus' third concern has to do with holiness (17:17-19). There is a spiritual dilemma that pertains to all disciples: They live in the world, and yet Jesus can say that they are not 'of the world' (17:14, 16). This points not to their location geographically, but to their position spiritually."[50]

v. 17 "Jesus prays that his disciples might be 'sanctified' (Gk. *hagiazo*) in the truth (17:17). This Greek word refers to something made holy, but the means to achieving this holiness is through separation. God is God by virtue of his difference, his transcendence, his otherness with respect to all creation. Anything (a mountain, a temple shovel, a priestly garment, a people) that belongs to him or serves his purposes should consider itself 'holy' and set apart from common use. To be holy, then, is not in the first instance a description of perfection (though this is included). It refers to a life that is so aligned with God that it reflects God's passions completely (for good, against evil). Such a person can be considered 'sanctified,' holy, attached to God's purposes and presence. In this case Jesus understands that a complete attachment to the truth discovered in God's Word will be the means of achieving this holiness (17:17b)."[51]

v. 19 "Perhaps 17:19 is one of the key verses in the prayer. When Jesus says that he sanctifies himself (Gk. *hagiazo*), to what does this refer? He may have in mind his self-dedication to his greater mission. Prophets and priests dedicated themselves thus. The Lord says to Jeremiah, 'Before I formed you in the womb I knew you, before you were born *I set you apart*' (Jer. 1:5, italics added). Priests likewise set themselves apart (Ex. 40:13; Lev. 8:30; 2 Chron. 5:11). But here in John 17:19 we learn that as a result of Jesus' consecration, his disciples will benefit. In the phrase 'for them,' 'for' (Gk. *hyper*, meaning 'for the sake of') implies sacrificial death throughout John (see 6:51; 10:11, 15; 11:50-52; 13:37; 15:13; 18:14)."[52]

vv. 20-26 "Jesus is aware that not only will he depart from the world, but likewise those who stand with him — his immediate circle of followers — will also depart to be with him in his glory (17:24). This will leave those whom they disciple, the church, to represent the kingdom in the world. Therefore Jesus now turns to pray for these followers whom he has not yet met, men and women who will follow the apostles, indeed the church today, which carries the mission set down by Jesus during his final week.

"This is the essence of Jesus' vision for the church. It is not a community that heals people just so that they will be whole (though healing is important); it is not a community that teaches so that people will be gratified by knowledge (though wisdom is valuable); it is not a community that evangelizes so that it will grow its ranks (though its mission to the world is crucial). The church is a community that invites people to touch the glory of God, to be changed by it, and to bear it to the world. 'This is to my Father's glory, that you bear much fruit, showing yourselves to be my disciples' (15:8). Spiritual fruit is essentially that which glorifies God.

"Such a concept forces us to ask hard questions about every aspect of what we do. 'Is God glorified here?' is the refrain that should accompany every decision. And the answer will not always be obvious or easy. But it must be asked because in Jesus' vision, this was the essential mission of his incarnate life and now is the essential mission of the church."[53]

50 Gary M. Burge, "John 17:1–26" In The NIV Application Commentary: John *(Grand Rapids, MI: Zondervan Publishing House, 2000), 457-481.*
51 Ibid.
52 Ibid.
53 Ibid.

Bible Text: John 17:1-5 (ESV)

John 17:1-5

- What "authority over all flesh" has Jesus been granted?
- Notice Jesus' definition of eternal life. In what ways can I pursue eternal life today?

John 17:1, 4-5

- What brings God glory? What specific work do I need to carry out on earth to bring God glory?

Journal

Please use one of the prompts below to get your journaling started.

- Recall a significant reaction, conversation or event.
- Explore your fears and what's behind them.
- Write about a relational conflict you are experiencing.
- List out all that you are grateful for.

Bible Text: John 17:6-19 (ESV)

John 17:6-19

- What did Jesus pray for his disciples, and what can I learn from the fact that these are the issues he prayed about?

John 17:11, 14-18

- What are the unique challenges Christians face as those who are "in the world" but "not of the world"?
- How have I experienced the sanctifying work of God's word in my life?

John 17:19

- How is Jesus' love for his disciples manifested in this verse? For whose sake do I need to consecrate myself in order that "they also may be sanctified in truth"?

Journal

Please use one of the prompts below to get your journaling started.

- Recall a significant reaction, conversation or event.
- Explore your fears and what's behind them.
- Write about a relational conflict you are experiencing.
- List out all that you are grateful for.

Memory Verse

John 16:33 (ESV)

"I have said these things to you, that in me you may have peace. In the world you will have tribulation. But take heart; I have overcome the world."

Journal

Please use one of the prompts below to get your journaling started.

- Recall a significant reaction, conversation or event.
- Explore your fears and what's behind them.
- Write about a relational conflict you are experiencing.
- List out all that you are grateful for.

Bible Text: John 17:20-26 (ESV)

John 17:20-23

- According to this passage, what is the basis and motivation for Christian unity?
- What is the relationship between oneness with God and oneness with the people of God?
- How does Jesus' final prayer for his disciples show me what my priority should be? How can I grow in experiencing this kind of oneness with the people of God?

Journal

Please use one of the prompts below to get your journaling started.

- Recall a significant reaction, conversation or event.
- Explore your fears and what's behind them.
- Write about a relational conflict you are experiencing.
- List out all that you are grateful for.

Bible Text: John 17:20-26 (ESV)

(This is the same Bible text as yesterday, with different reflection questions.)

John 17:24

- What is revealed about Jesus' heart in his prayer for his disciples to be with him in his glory?
- What assurance does this give me?

John 17:26

- How am I experiencing the process Jesus describes in v. 26?

Journal

Please use one of the prompts below to get your journaling started.

- Recall a significant reaction, conversation or event.
- Explore your fears and what's behind them.
- Write about a relational conflict you are experiencing.
- List out all that you are grateful for.

Commentary on John 18

v. 1 "Here they find a garden named by the Synoptics 'Gethsemane.' We should not think of a decorative garden like those built for pleasure in Europe or North America. This is an olive grove ('Gethsemane' means olive press), which grew along the west shoulder of the Mount of Olives."[54]

vv. 4-7 "But Jesus is not taken by surprise (18:4). In Mark 14:42 Jesus knows that Judas is coming before he arrives. Likewise here, Jesus' foreknowledge (1:47-48; 6:6; 13:1) gives him the ability to see the arrest before it unfolds. He does not shrink from the moment but has already made the decision to lay down his life under his own volition (10:18). Therefore Jesus steps forward and asks the first question, 'Who is it you want?'"[55]

v. 11 "Jesus then points to the 'cup' the Father has given him to drink (John 18:11). This reference recalls the Synoptic Gethsemane prayer, but now the struggle with Jesus' fate belongs to Peter, who cannot face the 'cup' that includes the cross. Jesus, by contrast, understands that this is God's will and so will not hesitate to embrace it."[56]

vv. 12-24 "Annas is well known even though he appears second to Caiaphas in the New Testament. Josephus indicates that he was appointed in A.D. 6 but was removed from office in A.D. 15 by Valerius Gratus, Pilate's predecessor. He continued to enjoy enormous influence, however, and considerable popular support since Judaism resented how the Romans controlled the high priesthood (his festival vestments were kept, for instance, in the Antonia Fortress). Five of Annas's sons became high priests as well as his son-in-law Caiaphas. Thus Annas enjoyed great power and was the patriarch of an influential priestly family, well known for its wealth, power, and greed."[57]

"Caiaphas and Annas represent men whose devotion to their religious careers and the political status quo exceeded their willingness to see God at work in Jesus. They have become the dangerous shepherds of chapter 10, whose interest in the welfare of the flock has been superseded by their own self-preservation."[58]

vv. 15-16 "Peter is accompanied, however, by 'another disciple,' who remains unnamed (18:15). This is curious since John has been careful to name people carefully (Annas, Caiaphas, Simon Peter, Malchus).

"[...] the view that this is the Beloved Disciple has a great deal to commend it. Throughout the gospel the Beloved Disciple frequently appears alongside Peter, a portrait also common in the Synoptics. The Beloved Disciple faithfully follows Jesus even to the site of the cross, where Jesus talks to him (John 19:25-27). His presence at the arrest shows his profound loyalty to Jesus so characteristic throughout the Gospel."[59]

v. 17 "Peter feels his vulnerability because the small courtyard also hosts officers and other servants (18:18a). Some of them may even remember that he attacked Malchus — another slave, whom this woman may know. So at the gate, to gain entry, Peter refuses to acknowledge his discipleship."[60]

vv. 20-21 "When Jesus affirms that he has taught openly (in the temple and in synagogues) and many can verify his work, he may sense that Annas is maneuvering to accuse him of being a false prophet. 'False prophesy' is the classic charge against Jesus reported in the Talmud (b. Sanh. 43a). To qualify as a false prophet one must 'secretly entice' or 'deceive' the people. The punishment for this was death (Deut. 13:1-11). Twice before this was precisely the suggestion uttered by the crowds (7:12) and the Pharisees (7:47)."[61]

vv. 37-38 "Of course, 'truth' is no foreign idea to Pilate. Everyone wants at least to claim that his or her efforts are true. Thus, Jesus' revelation that he is working for the truth serves as an invitation for Pilate to join him. For Pilate to condemn Jesus is for him to condemn the truth. Jesus has thus reversed positions with Pilate. In 9:29 Jesus said that he came into the world for judgment, unmasking the heartfelt dispositions of humanity. Ironically Jesus has been asking Pilate questions from the beginning. Now Pilate has been challenged (Will he side with truth or falsehood?) and now he carries the burden of response."[62]

54 Gary M. Burge, The NIV Application Commentary: John *(Grand Rapids, MI: Zondervan Publishing House, 2000), 491.*
55 Ibid., 492.
56 Ibid., 493
57 Ibid., 493.
58 Ibid., 511.
59 Ibid., 494.
60 Ibid., 495.
61 Ibid., 496.
62 Ibid., 501.

Bible Text: John 18:1-14 (ESV)

John 18:1-8

- Reflect on how Jesus went out to meet the approaching soldiers "knowing all that would happen to him." How does this contrast with my reaction when I need to move toward danger, discomfort or pain in the process of obeying God's will?
- What must Jesus have been like given that those who came to arrest him "drew back and fell to the ground" upon meeting him?

John 18:11

- What does Jesus' statement reveal about his posture toward "the cup that the Father has given [him]"?
- In what ways have I been (or am I being) tempted to "not drink the cup that the Father has given me"? Is there a "sword" Jesus calls me to put away, because I wield it to avoid the way of the cross?

Journal

Please use one of the prompts below to get your journaling started.

- Recall a significant reaction, conversation or event.
- Explore your fears and what's behind them.
- Write about a relational conflict you are experiencing.
- List out all that you are grateful for.

Bible Text: John 18:15-27 (ESV)

John 18:15-18, 25-27

- Reflect on the picture of Peter warming himself by a fire while Jesus is inside being interrogated and beaten. What does this reveal about human nature, and how does this apply to me?
- Are there some parallels between Peter's denial of being associated with Jesus and the way I live?

John 18:19-24

- In what ways are people like the officer who struck Jesus?
- What can I learn from what Jesus says in v. 23 about how to respond to words spoken to me?

Journal

Please use one of the prompts below to get your journaling started.

- Recall a significant reaction, conversation or event.
- Explore your fears and what's behind them.
- Write about a relational conflict you are experiencing.
- List out all that you are grateful for.

Memory Verse

John 17:22-23 (ESV)

"The glory that you have given me I have given to them, that they may be one even as we are one, I in them and you in me, that they may become perfectly one, so that the world may know that you sent me and loved them even as you loved me."

Journal

Please use one of the prompts below to get your journaling started.

- Recall a significant reaction, conversation or event.
- Explore your fears and what's behind them.
- Write about a relational conflict you are experiencing.
- List out all that you are grateful for.

Commentary on John 19

vv. 1-42 "Jesus as victor. Throughout the trial sequence [...] we learned how John portrays Jesus as the victorious king, knowing more than his captors and controlling the progress of events. Jesus is not a victim in this story. The same theme appears in the story of the cross. Jesus carries his own cross and requires no help (19:17). His opponents are powerless to alter the regal title of his cross. His final cry is significant as well: 'It is finished' (19:30). The word used here can mean 'to bring to an end,' but it bears the nuance of 'to fulfill' or 'bring to completion.' In 4:34 Jesus described his 'food' as doing God's will and completing his work. In 17:4 Jesus uses the same verb again: 'I have brought you glory on earth by completing the work you gave me to do.' Now on the cross Jesus is finished as he brings to completion his divine tasks.

"Why is this important? 'It is finished' is our signal that God has succeeded in accomplishing everything he designed to do in the life of his Son. In Jesus Christ God himself was at work demonstrating his love for us, revealing his will for our lives, and bringing about a reconciliation that needs no supplement. Jesus' victory is the basis of our security. My confidence in God and the assurance of my salvation cannot be anchored in my religious performance. 'It is finished.' What was needed to satisfy God ought to satisfy us as well. This is the good news of the gospel."[63]

vv. 1-7 "When Pilate escorts Jesus outside, his clear intention is to display Jesus in cruel submission, bearing the marks of his punishment, and thereby obtain his release. John's famous 'Here is the man' records Pilate's words as he tries to evoke sympathy for Jesus' pathetic state. Jesus is in sore condition; he no doubt is bleeding profusely and terribly bruised. Pilate also announces for the second time that Jesus is innocent, but Pilate's overture fails when his audience calls for Jesus' death."[64]

vv. 10-11 "The real power above both Caesar and Pilate is God, and so Pilate has no grounds for boasting. No one can take the Son's life away from him (10:18). No one! God has permitted Pilate to have this power over Jesus because it is a necessary aspect of what will happen in 'the hour.' Jesus must die. In the story Pilate has tried to use what power he enjoys to free Jesus, but it doesn't work. Pilate is powerless before God's plan in this hour."[65]

vv. 12-16 '' 'Friend of Caesar' was an official title bestowed on select persons such as senators who showed marked loyalty and service to the emperor. If Pilate is not a friend, he is an enemy of Caesar, and Emperor Tiberius had a firm reputation for eliminating his enemies swiftly. Suetonius tells of Roman leaders killed for simply removing statues of Augustus or for criticizing him.

"The irony of this situation is that these Jewish leaders, who come from a province seething with hatred for Rome, are here chastising the governor for not being sufficiently loyal. But Pilate has reason for worry. Jewish delegations were known to travel to the Roman Senate to complain about the work of governors, putting careers in danger. Pilate has seen this with some of his own friends. Therefore Pilate's powerlessness is all the more apparent and at once his resolve is broken."[66]

v. 15 "'We have no king but Caesar' is a direct contradiction of the injunction of the Bible that God alone is Israel's king (1 Sam. 8:7; 10:19) and the kings that did reign (e.g., David) did so by divine appointment. By rejecting Jesus they have rejected God himself, as Jesus predicted, 'He who does not honor the Son does not honor the Father, who sent him' (John 5:23)."[67]

vv. 1-16 Flogging. "The delinquent was stripped, bound to a post or a pillar, or sometimes simply thrown on the ground, and beaten by a number of torturers until the latter grew tired and the flesh of the delinquent hung in bleeding shreds. In the provinces this was the task of the soldiers. Three kinds of implements were customary. Rods were used on freemen; military punishments were inflected with sticks, but for slaves scourges or whips were used, the leather thongs of these being often fitted with a spike or with several pieces of bone or lead joined to form a chain. The scourging of Jesus was carried out with these last-named instruments. It is not surprising to hear that delinquents frequently collapsed and died under this procedure which only in exceptional cases was prescribed as a death sentence. Josephus records that he himself had some of his opponents in the Galilean Tarichae scourged until their entrails were visible. The case of Jesus bar Hanan, the prophet of woe, whom the procurator Albinus had

63 Gary M. Burge, The NIV Application Commentary: John *(Grand Rapids, MI: Zondervan Publishing House, 2000), 546.*
64 Ibid., 503.
65 Ibid., 505
66 Ibid., 506.
67 Ibid., 507.

scourged until his bones lay bare ... also makes one realize what the little word 'to scourge' in Mark 15:15 means."[68]

vv. 16-42 "The practice of crucifixion is somewhat debated. We know that thousands of slaves and criminals were crucified, but we have no complete description of the process [...]. But literary references make clear that this was a death reserved for lower classes, slaves, foreigners, and criminals. The victim was laid on the ground with his arms stretched across the beam. After he was either nailed or tied, he was hoisted up and mounted on the vertical post.

"Various postures on the cross were possible but the least likely appears in Christian art (with the nails inserted on top of the foot). Romans nailed the ankles together, forcing the feet to lay sideways on top of one another. They also kept a peg on the vertical post for the person to sit on and hence not tear away. The key is to remember that nailing was not the means of death on the cross. Many factors, such as hemorrhaging, asphyxia, and shock, played a role. It is easy to see why Josephus (who watched many crucifixions during Titus's conquest of Jerusalem) referred to this as 'the most wretched of deaths."[69]

vv. 19-23 "It comes as no surprise that the chief priests are furious and insulted. They understand that the sign implies a kind of sarcastic endorsement by Rome of Jesus' royal identity, and they do not like it. 'This man said, 'I am King of the Jews' ' (NRSV) is their biting alternative, but Pilate for the first time in the story stands up to them."[70]

vv. 25-27 "Jesus now is appealing to a family responsibility that will be a feature of John's own discipleship. His form of address ('Woman!') is respectful, and he is pointing Mary to John (the Beloved Disciple), placing her under the protective care of this disciple.

"All of this makes sense when we think that Jesus' brothers have abandoned him (7:5), and the absence of Joseph in the story makes us suspect that Mary is alone. She has supported Jesus all along, and now with his death, a woman in her culture would be bereft and at risk. The Beloved Disciple is being called now to take Mary into his family, and he does this obediently."[71]

v. 30 "This confirms the sense we have seen throughout the Passion story that here Jesus is accomplishing what he intends. He is not a victim, but a servant doing God's bidding. This is not a cry of desolation ('At last it is over!') but an announcement of triumph ('It is accomplished')."[72]

vv. 38-42 "Nicodemus brings a considerable number of burial spices. Myrrh was an embalming powder commonly used in Egypt; aloe was a fragrant powdered sandalwood used generally as a perfume. The weight of these two spices is about seventy-five pounds. This is a remarkable amount and is reminiscent of the excessive wine in Cana (2:1–10) that marked Jesus' first public appearance."[73]

68 Ibid., 509.
69 Ibid., 525.
70 Ibid., 526.
71 Ibid., 528.
72 Ibid., 529.
73 Ibid., 535.

Bible Text: John 18:28-19:1 (ESV)

John 18:28

- Reflect on the irony of the Jews not entering the palace "so that they would not be defiled, but could eat the Passover" while they were bent on having Pilate kill an innocent man. What lessons or warnings might there be for me?

John 18:33-19:1

- What can I learn about Jesus' heart through his interaction with Pilate?
- Contrast Jesus' view of truth with Pilate's view of truth as revealed by his action (19:1).

Journal

Please use one of the prompts below to get your journaling started.

- Recall a significant reaction, conversation or event.
- Explore your fears and what's behind them.
- Write about a relational conflict you are experiencing.
- List out all that you are grateful for.

Bible Text: John 18:33-19:16a (ESV)

"Realizing that the priests were implacable and that resisting them would only endanger his career, Pilate finally gave in and ordered the Crucifixion. Certain features of Pilate's examination of Jesus are significant. Pilate's behavior shows that he was apprehensive of trouble. From the outset he was uncertain of his position. He oscillated between public confrontation with the Jewish mob and private interrogation of Jesus. Seven times in this brief narrative the author says or implies that Pilate 'went out' or 'went in' (18:29, 33, 38; 19:1, 4, 9, 13). Beneath his arrogant manner, there was an uncertainty that came from the conflict between Pilate the Roman judge and Pilate the politician. He finally succumbed to expediency."[74]

John 18:39-19:16

- How many times did Pilate declare Jesus' innocence? Despite this, he ultimately hands Jesus over to be crucified. Note the progression, and consider what Pilate forfeits in order to preserve his political position.
- In what ways have I seen this play out in our world today?
- What is the irony of Pilate saying, "Do you not know that I have authority to release you and authority to crucify you"? What can I learn about true power from Jesus' response to Pilate?

74 Frank E. Gaebelein, Expositor's Bible Commentary CD *(Grand Rapids: Zondervan Pub. House, 1992), notes for John chapter 19.*

Journal

Please use one of the prompts below to get your journaling started.

- Recall a significant reaction, conversation or event.
- Explore your fears and what's behind them.
- Write about a relational conflict you are experiencing.
- List out all that you are grateful for.

Bible Text: John 19:16b-30 (ESV)

*"The use of the perfect tense in 'It is finished' (*tetelestai*) signifies full completion of Jesus' work and the establishment of a basis for faith. Nothing further needed to be done. Jesus' act was voluntary and confident, for he had discharged perfectly the Father's purpose and was leaving the scene of his human struggle. [...] Jesus retained consciousness and command of himself till the very end."*[75]

- Reflect on Jesus' final words: "It is finished." What truths are contained in this final declaration?
- Reflect on the following passages in light of Jesus' death on the cross. What personal connections can I make?

John 10:14–18

"I am the good shepherd. I know my own and my own know me, just as the Father knows me and I know the Father; and I lay down my life for the sheep. And I have other sheep that are not of this fold. I must bring them also, and they will listen to my voice. So there will be one flock, one shepherd. For this reason the Father loves me, because I lay down my life that I may take it up again. No one takes it from me, but I lay it down of my own accord. I have authority to lay it down, and I have authority to take it up again. This charge I have received from my Father."

John 12:27, 32

"Now is my soul troubled. And what shall I say? 'Father, save me from this hour'? But for this purpose I have come to this hour. ... And I, when I am lifted up from the earth, will draw all people to myself."

75 Frank E. Gaebelein, Expositor's Bible Commentary CD *(Grand Rapids: Zondervan Pub. House, 1992), notes for John chapter 19.*

Journal

Please use one of the prompts below to get your journaling started.

- Recall a significant reaction, conversation or event.
- Explore your fears and what's behind them.
- Write about a relational conflict you are experiencing.
- List out all that you are grateful for.

Bible Text: John 19:31-42 (ESV)

"Joseph's action was courageous, for his petition was a tacit admission that he was a friend of Jesus and consequently an associate in whatever supposed subversion Jesus might have advocated. Joseph took the initiative and petitioned Pilate for permission to remove the body. His request was an open confession of his faith, for up to this time he had been a secret believer. [...] Like Joseph, Nicodemus was a secret disciple whose faith grew slowly...his cooperation with Joseph in the burial shows that his faith had finally matured."[76]

John 19:38-39

- What would have motivated Joseph of Arimathea to ask Pilate for Jesus' body and Nicodemus to bring "a mixture of myrrh and aloes, about seventy-five pounds"?
- What was the significance of their actions?
- How do their actions show what my response to the cross should be?

76 Frank E. Gaebelein, Expositor's Bible Commentary CD *(Grand Rapids: Zondervan Pub. House, 1992), notes for John chapter 19.*

Journal

Please use one of the prompts below to get your journaling started.

- Recall a significant reaction, conversation or event.
- Explore your fears and what's behind them.
- Write about a relational conflict you are experiencing.
- List out all that you are grateful for.

Memory Verse

John 12:32 (ESV)

"And I, when I am lifted up from the earth, will draw all people to myself."

Journal

Please use one of the prompts below to get your journaling started.

- Recall a significant reaction, conversation or event.
- Explore your fears and what's behind them.
- Write about a relational conflict you are experiencing.
- List out all that you are grateful for.

Commentary on John 20

vv. 6-7 "The scene, then, is not chaotic or confused. Rather, something purposeful has transpired here. If someone had simply stolen Jesus' body, surely the clothes would be missing, or at least strewn about the floor. But here is a scene in which the body is missing but the clothes appear undisturbed. Jesus' body has simply left them behind."[77]

v. 8, 24-28 "We are invited — no, we are challenged — to believe like Thomas. Yet John understands perfectly well that we do not have the same opportunities. 'Blessed are those who have not seen and yet have believed.' This is why in the story of John 20 the Beloved Disciple becomes one of the most important figures. He looks into the tomb, sees the evidence, and believes (20:8). While not seeing the resurrected Jesus, he sees what has been left behind; he sees the remnants of divine activity in history in stone and fabric and decides to believe."[78]

v. 17 "In telling her not to hold on, Jesus is saying that his permanent 'return' and presence must come in another form. She cannot embrace what she finds in the garden. Things are going to change. Jesus' correction is a spiritual redirection away from Jesus' physical presence, a preparation for the Spirit that is about to be given."[79]

vv. 21-22 "Throughout this Gospel Jesus has been described as the One who was sent by God. Now with his work nearly completed, his final task is to commission his followers as he was commissioned by the Father. Thus as Jesus was God's special representative (or agent) in the world, so too his disciples become Jesus' agents, working in the world and witnessing to the reality of God and the truth of Jesus' words.

"But in this Gospel one feature of Jesus' commission is his empowering. God not only sent his Son but also empowered him with the Spirit. For example, in Jesus' baptism the central event (from John's view) was not the water baptism itself, but the anointing in the Spirit that came to Jesus. Our first introduction of Jesus came from the prophetic words of John the Baptist, whom God had told, 'The man on whom you see the Spirit come down and remain is he who will baptize with the Holy Spirit' (1:33).

"[...] Therefore to be commissioned (20:21), to advance the work of God as God's agent, means being empowered as Jesus was empowered — obtaining the Spirit, just as Jesus was anointed and as Jesus promised."[80]

vv. 21-23 "The gift of the Spirit is framed with two messages outlining aspects of the church's work in the world. In 20:21 we observed how the disciples will enjoy a mission that parallels the mission of Jesus (cf. 17:18a). And in 20:23 Jesus points to their ability to forgive sin (no doubt as a part of that mission)."[81]

v. 22 "This is no impersonal spirit; this is no ambiguous inspiration from God. This is Jesus himself indwelling his disciples, taking up the residence promised in 14:23. Jesus desires intimacy with Mary and his followers, but the vehicle of that intimacy will now be experienced through the agency of the Holy Spirit. The reason that the work of the Spirit in John 14–16 is so highly personal is that this Spirit is the Spirit of Jesus — his own Spirit — that is now poured out at the hour of glorification."[82]

vv. 24-28 "In the final scene, we meet Thomas, a man no different from us. He is a man for whom faith will only be a reality when the concrete evidence of resurrection is provided to him. He possesses no experience at an empty tomb, nor has he heard or seen Jesus. Thus, faith seems for him daunting and impossible. Thomas becomes a template for us, who read the story of Jesus from a distance. We hear the report, we read John's Gospel, and at once we are challenged to believe."[83]

"Jesus' exhortation, 'Stop doubting and believe,' [...]. Thomas is being challenged to change, to become like the others who, upon seeing Jesus, embrace him with faith. His response, 'My Lord and my God!', is not a word of astonishment or praise to God. It is a confession of Thomas's heartfelt belief in Jesus. Thus we learn that 'the most outrageous doubter of the resurrection of Jesus utters the greatest confession of the Lord who rose from the dead.'"[84]

v. 29 "Jesus has in mind people (such as ourselves) who are now reading this Gospel and have not had Thomas's

77 Gary M. Burge, The NIV Application Commentary: John *(Grand Rapids, MI: Zondervan Publishing House, 2000), 554.*
78 Ibid., 572.
79 Ibid., 556-557.
80 Ibid., 558-559.
81 Ibid., 561.
82 Ibid., 575.
83 Ibid., 566.
84 Ibid., 562-563.

opportunity to touch Jesus' wounds. There can be no more remarkable privilege. But John has provided us with a record of signs — his Gospel — that can serve us in a similar capacity. While not doing what Thomas did, we have his story, and this should give us a reasonable ground for belief."[85]

v. 31 "In 20:31 John discloses his purpose for writing the Gospel. Belief leads to life, and this life is a gift given through the power of Jesus Christ, God's Son."[86]

85 Ibid., 563.
86 Ibid., 564.

Bible Text: John 20:1-19 (ESV)

John 20:2-8

- What do the disciples demonstrate about the relationship between hearing, responding, and believing?
- Think about the process by which I came to believe in the resurrection of Jesus.

John 20:11-16, 19

- Contrast Mary with the disciples, who were huddled together with "the doors being locked...for fear of the Jews." What made Mary so bold?

John 20:17

- What is amazing about Jesus calling his disciples his "brothers" after they had deserted him?
- What can I learn about the criteria for being part of God's family and having the right to call God my Father and my God?

Journal

Please use one of the prompts below to get your journaling started.

- Recall a significant reaction, conversation or event.
- Explore your fears and what's behind them.
- Write about a relational conflict you are experiencing.
- List out all that you are grateful for.

Bible Text: John 20:19-31 (ESV)

"The disciples did not have the power to forgive sins (only God can forgive sins), but Jesus gave them the privilege of telling new believers that their sins have been forgiven because they have accepted Jesus' message."[87]

John 20:19-23

- What was the first responsibility that the risen Jesus gave to the disciples (vv. 22-23)?
- What has been my response to this calling?

John 20:24-29

- How did Jesus deal with Thomas' doubt, and how did Thomas come to his confession that Jesus is indeed his Lord and his God?

"To believe that Jesus is the Christ (Messiah) and the Son of God involves the total acceptance of the revelation of God that he offers, the acknowledgment of his divine authority, and the fulfillment of the commission he entrusted to his disciples. The total scope of this belief is illustrated in the narrative of this Gospel. Its result is eternal life, a new and enduring experience of God by the believer."[88]

John 20:30-31

- What was John's purpose in writing the Gospel of John? What does it mean to have "life in his name," and in what ways have I experienced that life?

87 Life Application Study Bible, *study notes (co-published by Grand Rapids, MI: Zondervan; Wheaton, IL: Tyndale House, 1991), 1927.*
88 *Frank E. Gaebelein,* Expositor's Bible Commentary CD *(Grand Rapids: Zondervan Pub. House, 1992), notes for John chapter 20.*

Journal

Please use one of the prompts below to get your journaling started.

- Recall a significant reaction, conversation or event.
- Explore your fears and what's behind them.
- Write about a relational conflict you are experiencing.
- List out all that you are grateful for.

Commentary on John 21

Introduction: "The fishing miracle of chapter 21 is not a sign for unbelievers, compelling them to believe in the resurrected Christ. Chapter 21 is an epilogue addressed to the church and its responsibilities and work in the world. The principal story in the chapter — the great catch of fish and Jesus' subsequent conversation around the morning fire — reinforces the apostolic commission to take responsibility for those who come into the kingdom of Christ. Peter is to be fisherman and shepherd; some followers even may be called to be martyrs, but each has a task to glorify God by obediently following Jesus."[89]

vv. 7-17 "When Peter learned that it was Jesus who had done this — the fishing-miracle-worker Jesus — it is no accident that he ran to the shore. He ran to the only one who could heal his memories, who could rewrite the terrible pictures and sounds of his recent past — the courtyard, the charcoal fire, the young woman. The miracle demonstrated that despite Peter's failings, Jesus was still on his side, cooking a good meal for friends, having fun filling nets with fish. Then the invitation to affirm his love three times drowned out the echoes of his betrayal that haunted him. The last time Peter stood over a charcoal fire, he denied Jesus (18:18). Now Jesus makes him stand over another charcoal fire (21:9) and with it, review old memories and remove them."[90]

vv. 15-17 "The story of Peter's reconciliation to Jesus is a story of Peter's healing. It is no accident that Peter, the man who denied Jesus three times following a bravado-filled promise of faithfulness, now affirms his love for Christ three times."[91]

"Peter's restoration to Christ makes possible his service to the church. Jesus' command to feed and tend his sheep becomes Peter's mandate for life. He affirms his love for Jesus, but now he understands that this means a great deal more. [...] To be in a relationship with Christ and to love him genuinely means that we must also love the church."[92]

v. 18 "This language points clearly to crucifixion; the Greek word used here was used by many early Christian writers to represent death on the cross. [...] In old age, Peter will not be 'dressed' (NIV), but 'bound', as many victims were 'fastened' with ropes to the cross. Those who lead him will not be charitable, but will force him to go where he does not want to."[93]

vv. 20-22 "The gentle rivalry between Peter and the Beloved Disciple reaches its peak in this chapter. We do not have enough information to probe beneath the surface to learn what transpired between these two men. But in 21:21 Peter finally unmasks his feelings: 'Lord, what about him? What about this other man on the margin of our conversation? Will his death rival mine in bringing you glory?' Jesus' rebuke is a rebuke to each of us."[94]

89 Gary M. Burge, The NIV Application Commentary: John (Grand Rapids, MI: Zondervan Publishing House, 2000), 592.
90 Ibid., 596.
91 Ibid., 593.
92 Ibid., 598.
93 Ibid., 589.
94 Ibid., 593.

Bible Text: John 21:1-14 (ESV)

"'Afterward' implies an indefinite lapse of time (cf. 2:12; 3:22; 5:1, 14; 6:1; 7:1; 11:7, 11; 13:7; 19:28, 38), but not always a long time. Since this event is categorized as Jesus' third appearance to the disciples after the Resurrection (21:14), it must have taken place between the beginning of the second week and the Ascension."[95]

John 21:1-3

- Why might Peter have gone back to fishing even after witnessing the resurrection?
- What is the significance of the disciples going back to fishing and catching nothing (cf. Mark 1:16-17)?
- What do I do when I experience disappointment or failure?

John 21:4-7

- What events have there been in my life of which I can say, "it [was] the Lord"? How does remembering my personal history bring clarity to my relationship with God?

95 *Frank E. Gaebelein,* Expositor's Bible Commentary CD *(Grand Rapids: Zondervan Pub. House, 1992), notes for John chapter 21.*

Journal

Please use one of the prompts below to get your journaling started.

- Recall a significant reaction, conversation or event.
- Explore your fears and what's behind them.
- Write about a relational conflict you are experiencing.
- List out all that you are grateful for.

Bible Text: John 21:15-25 (ESV)

John 21:15-17

- What can I learn about God's perspective on my failures through Jesus' interaction with Peter?
- What can I learn about God's calling—"tend my sheep"—given that Jesus asks this of Peter, who had denied and failed him?

John 21:18-19

- How is the contrast between the time when one is "young" and "old" in v. 18 an apt description of Christian maturity? In what ways have I grown in allowing others to lead me where I do not want to go?
- Jesus commanded Peter, "Follow me," which were the same words he used when he first called him to discipleship. How might these words have taken on a new and deeper meaning after everything that had happened?
- Are there ways that Jesus is asking me to follow him in a deeper way today?

Journal

Please use one of the prompts below to get your journaling started.

- Recall a significant reaction, conversation or event.
- Explore your fears and what's behind them.
- Write about a relational conflict you are experiencing.
- List out all that you are grateful for.

Memory Verse

John 20:31 (ESV)

But these are written so that you may believe that Jesus is the Christ, the Son of God, and that by believing you may have life in his name.